

The logo for PRG, featuring the letters 'PRG' in a bold, stylized font. The 'P' and 'R' are solid black, while the 'G' is a thick, rounded, 3D-style letter with a dark blue-to-purple gradient and a white highlight on its upper curve.



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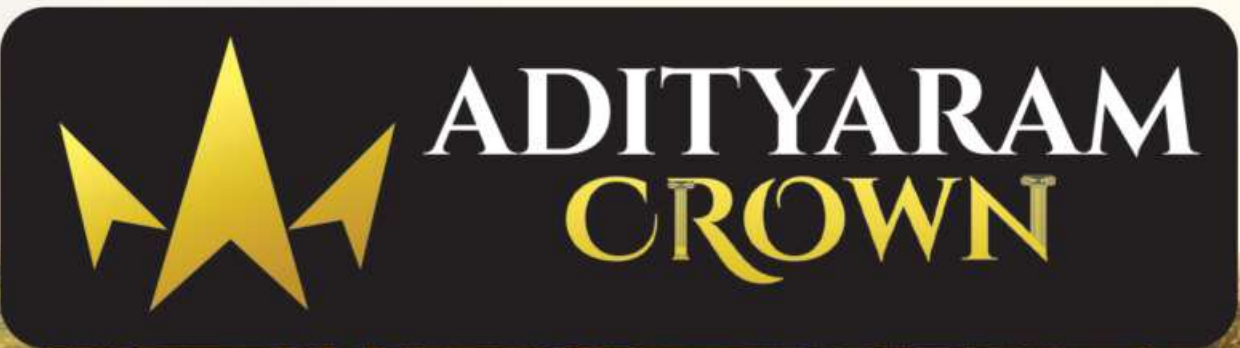
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NEWS » PAGE 11



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PM pitches India as hub for chipmaking
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NEET-SS CASE
Qualifying percentile will be cut to 30: govt.
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PARLEY
Does BRICS meet signify a foreign policy shift?
Delhi declaration slams western sanctions, Israel
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DOMINANT DISPLAY
Abhishek dazzles as India sweeps series
SPORT » PAGE 15

U.S. clears Russia sanctions Bill; India faces tariff threat

U.S. House clears legislation that will authorise the President to impose 100% tariffs on countries for buying oil and gas from Russia; committed to ensuring energy security for Indians, says New Delhi

Sriram Lakshman
WASHINGTON DC

The U.S. House of Representatives on Wednesday passed legislation targeting Russia's energy sector, individuals and the "shadow fleet" of tankers, including authorising the U.S. President to impose tariffs of up to 100% on India and other countries for buying oil and gas from Russia. The House voted 262-159 in favour of the Bill.

The Bill, an amendment to the Senate's "Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026", will now head to President Donald Trump's desk for his signature. Mr. Trump plans to sign the Bill, a White House official told *The Hindu* on Thursday. The President will have the

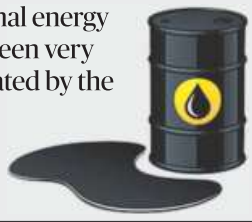
Who are the targets?

The Bill aims to dissuade countries from 'aiding Russian aggression' against Ukraine by purchasing Russian oil and gas

The Bill targets top five "largest importers, by total volume" in the 12 months preceding the date of enactment of the law, which have knowingly made new purchases on or after 30 days from the date the Bill becomes law

This issue has been discussed at high levels in recent months with various U.S. interlocutors. Its potential implications for not just the bilateral relationship but also the international energy market have been very clearly articulated by the Indian side

EXTERNAL AFFAIRS MINISTRY



Over half of oil imports in July were from Russia

NEW DELHI

Russia accounted for more than 51% of India's oil imports in July, an all-time-high, up from just a little less than 50% in the previous month, the latest official data show. An analysis of Commerce and Industry Ministry data shows India imported 110.4 lakh tonnes of Russian oil in July, the latest month for which data are available. » PAGE 13

Delhi and Washington have been negotiating a preliminary trade deal.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10
CHINA, RUSSIA REACT
» PAGE 14

NEARBY



Thousands attend consecration of Meenakshi temple

MADURAI

Thousands of devotees witnessed the Kumbabhishhekam (consecration) of Madurai Sri Meenakshi Sundareswarar Temple on Thursday. » PAGE 6

E.M. Sudarsana Natchiappan dies aged 78

SIVAGANGA

Senior Congress leader and former Union Minister E.M. Sudarsana Natchiappan passed away in Sivaganga on Thursday. He was 78. » PAGE 6

FRIDAY REVIEW » 4 PAGES

Tata Sons Board backs N. Chandrasekaran; Trusts terms it illegal

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

A major dispute has arisen between Tata Sons Pvt. Ltd.'s Board and its majority owner, Tata Trusts, regarding the reappointment of N. Chandrasekaran as Tata Sons chairman and the listing of the company as mandated by Reserve Bank of India guidelines. Tata Trusts has termed the appointment "illegal".

On Thursday, at a scheduled board meeting of Tata Sons, the Board requested Mr. Chandrasekaran to reconsider his decision to not seek reappointment and continue for five years and he "acceded to the request".

"The Board thereafter resolved by a majority vote to re-appoint him as Executive Chairman for a further



N. Chandrasekaran

term of five years upon the expiry of his current tenure [in February 2027]," Tata Sons said in a statement.

On August 12, Mr. Chandrasekaran had said that he would not seek reappointment since one board member, Noel Tata, did not approve it.

NOEL TATA OPPOSES BID
» PAGE 10

T.N. says CM's U.K. trip drew ₹15,300-crore investment commitments

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, who visited the U.K. to meet industrialists and attract investments to the State, returned to Chennai on Thursday. A press release said investment commitments worth ₹15,300 crore had been received during the visit, which would generate 10,000 direct and indirect jobs.

Mr. Vijay met Indian High Commissioner Kumaran Periyasamy and held discussions on joint ventures between India and the U.K. under the Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA).

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 6

After claiming death benefits, 2,500 Odisha workers return for ration

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

In a bid to hoodwink Odisha's welfare machinery, almost 2,500 construction workers appear to have defied the rules of mortality — they died on paper, collected death benefits, and then came back to life to authenticate their Aadhaar and collect their monthly ration.

An audit has blown the lid off what appears to be a bizarre and massive fraud under the State's Nirman Shramik welfare scheme. As many as 2,487 construc-



ILLUSTRATION: SOUMYADIP SINHA

tion workers were declared dead and their nominees were paid death assistance, even though the workers continued to draw subsidised food

grains under the National Food Security Act (NFSA) and State Food Security Scheme after their recorded deaths.

The contradiction be-

comes even more startling in 753 cases. The audit found that these beneficiaries authenticated their Aadhaar biometrically to obtain ration after they had officially been declared dead. Death assistance amounting to ₹15.10 crore was subsequently paid to their nominees.

In other words, the government's records had buried the workers, while its ration system was still recognising their fingerprints.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

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CM
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M CH-CH

INBRIEF



Prof. K.S. Hegde Memorial Endowment Lecture held

The Alumni Association of College of Engineering Guindy (CEG), Anna University, organised the Prof. K.S. Hegde Memorial Endowment Lecture on ‘Technology for Grassroots People’ in Chennai on Thursday. A press release said S. Rajesh Kannan, Deputy Commissioner of Police, Kolathur, Greater Chennai Police, an alumnus of CEG, delivered the lecture. He emphasised the importance of the responsible use of technology and artificial intelligence. He also encouraged students to make effective use of the learning environment available at the CEG to identify and develop solutions to real-world social challenges.

City hospital treats man with year-long severe pelvic pain

A 36-year-old Sri Lankan man suffering from severe burning pelvic pain for nearly a year underwent a minimally invasive procedure at Dr. Mehta's Hospitals in Chetpet. The patient was referred to Premkumar M., head of anaesthesia and senior interventional pain management specialist at the hospital, a press release said. An evaluation found that he had significant nerve damage in the pelvic region following transverse myelitis, a rare inflammatory condition affecting the spinal cord. As per the release, the patient reportedly experienced significant pain relief and was able to return to his normal routine following the procedure.

‘Today’s Chennai is bustling on several fronts, but my heart still beats for the old Madras’

Born in Egmore Maternity Hospital, I grew up in the government quarters at Todd Hunter Nagar in Saidapet.

It was a sprawling campus with over 500 houses, warm neighbours, and abundant green cover.

Every Pongal, we celebrated ‘Nagar Day’ with fanfare, and there would be competitions, sports activities, and a three-day drama performance.

My younger brother Suresh and I, both child artists, played major roles.

Old Madras was an unhurried city with its



‘Appa’ Ramesh, artiste and writer.

own charm, from the friendly provision stores, where the owner knew your family, to the huge Spencer Plaza on Mount Road, which was the precursor to today's malls.

I yearn for those old theatres – New Elphin-

Sembakkam Lake continues to suffer sewage pollution

Residents allege that the waterbody remains vulnerable due to the inaction of govt. authorities. Absence of an underground sewerage network in nearby areas is another major reason, they add

ECO WATCH

K. Lakshmi
CHENNAI

Sembakkam Lake, one of the major water bodies in southern fringes of the city, continues to face sewage pollution despite frequent representations for over three years now.

Chitlapakkam residents said though the Northeast monsoon was around the corner, the waterbody remained choked with aquatic weeds, as monsoon preparedness work was yet to begin. Spread over nearly 100 acres, the lake is polluted with sewage released through stormwater drains (SWDs) and channels bringing floodwater from catchment areas such as Pachamalai Hills. Residents of Sri Sarvamangala Nagar said the lake continued to be vulnerable to sewage pollution due to inadequate action by the government authorities.

Members of the Sri Sarvamangala Nagar Residents' Welfare Association said domestic sewage entered the lake through the SWDs in Thiru. Vi. ka. Na-



Sorry state: A recent report by the Tamil Nadu Pollution Control Board says Sembakkam Lake's major portion is covered by water hyacinth, indicating sewage contamination. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

gar and Sarvamangala Nagar First Main Road. The absence of an underground sewer network in areas, including Maheswari Nagar, Iyappa Nagar, and Hasthinapuram, led to sewage being discharged into the lake. The association had filed a case before the National Green Tribunal (NGT), Southern Zone, seeking action against sewage pollution in the lake in 2017.

Citing a recent report submitted by the Tamil Nadu Pollution Control Board (TNPCB) before the NGT, M. Ravi, the association's secretary, said the report mentioned areas sur-

rounding the lake were yet to be provided with a sewerage network. A major portion of the lake was covered by water hyacinth, indicating sewage contamination, it said.

Water analysis
Water samples were collected and the analysis report is awaited. However, an earlier TNPCB analysis of water samples collected in 2024 found that faecal coliform and total coliform exceeded prescribed standards, indicating sewage in the lake. Though a sewerage network has been provided in some parts, house service connections are yet

to be given. Sewage from the incomplete sewerage network was also let out into the lake, residents said.

The Water Resources Department and Tambaram Municipal Corporation highlighted proposals to restore the lake, prevent sewage release, and clear encroachments. But the projects are yet to materialise and the delay was also raised in the recent NGT directive, said Mr. Ravi. Residents urged authorities to link the existing sewerage network to Hasthinapuram and Perungudi sewage pumping stations and implement restoration measures at the lake.

Man held for cheating woman of 155 sovereigns of gold jewellery

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The All-Women Police, Tiruvottiur, have arrested Harikrishnan, 27, for allegedly obtaining around 155 sovereigns gold jewellery from a 33-year-old woman

on various pretexts and later threatening to upload her photographs on social media when she demanded the jewellery back.

She became acquainted with Harikrishnan on Instagram in 2024. The police said Harikrishnan sub-

sequently approached the woman on several occasions, claiming that he urgently needed money. He allegedly told her that if she gave him gold jewellery, he could pawn it and return them after repaying the loan.

Police receive more allegations of sexual abuse against granite baron R. Veeramani

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

More survivors of sexual abuse involving granite baron R. Veeramani have given statement to the police that they were “exploited” by him.

According to police sources, investigators found evidence that at least nine minor girls had been sexually abused by the businessman.

Relying on the credible information, they identified some girls who gave statements that they had also been abused over the years. They were then minors. The allegations made by the girls would be thoroughly inquired into before taking further action, the sources said.

A special team probing the case booked under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act came across a message sent to Veeramani, who is the chairman, Gem group of companies, and Chairman and Managing Director of city-based Gem Granites, which pointed to the exploitation of girls belonging to families living below the poverty line, the sources said.

Veeramani and his associates Shanti and her husband Mahendra Simhan were arrested after investigation in the case registered in October 2025 revealed their involvement. “Veeramani is clearly seen in the video abusing the minor girl. The statement of a co-accused and victims revealed his pedophile nature,” a police officer told ‘The Hindu’ on Thursday.

Parrying questions on how the police managed to identify the victim seen in the 2019 video and others,

A city court on Thursday granted the police 3-day custody of Veeramani. He will be questioned at the Puzhal Central Prison complex

the officer said the police would not reveal any information that could lead to their location or identity.

Financial aid
“We have assured them (the victims) of complete secrecy. The child seen in the video belongs to a Scheduled Caste community and steps have been taken to provide financial assistance to her under an existing welfare scheme,” the officer who did not want to be quoted said.

Investigation was on to gather more information on the message sent by Shanti, one of the accused, to Veeramani whether he remembered the death of a girl in 2003, the sources said.

On Wednesday, the police informed the designated court for POCSO Act cases about the identity of the victim seen in the video and recorded her statement.

Commissioner of Police A. Amalraj reviewed the progress in the case with senior officers at the Commissionerate and instructed the team to expedite the process of filing charge sheet at the earliest, police sources said.

A city court on Thursday granted the police three-day custody of Veeramani. Considering the age of the accused, the police would question him at the Puzhal Central Prison complex.

CINEMA ♦ ARTS ♦ EVENTS

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

The Music Academy Madras
Today: From 10.00 a.m. to 12 Noon At the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall – Workshop titled: Sankirtana Saurabham – compositions of Annamacharya by Sri. Malladi Suribabu - Registration - Rs. 50/- . Students and rasikas welcome. Contact Music Academy Office – 28112251 / 28115162. Programme under the endowment of late Smt. Pankajam Krishna, Smt. Prabha Nagarajan and Sri. Ravi Subramanian in memory of their father late Sri. K S Iyer – HMV. **Programme supported by KVB CSR initiative.**

The Music Academy Madras
Today from 6.00 p.m. to 7.30 p.m. at the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall – Presentation of Archival Vintage Concerts of Vidwan Dr. S Pinakapani by Malladi Brothers – Sri. Sreeramadas & Dr. Ravikumar. Programme under the endowment instituted by Smt. Gayathri Srikanth and Sri. Rajan Srikanth in memory of Smt. Rajammal Vijayaraghavan. **Programme supported by KVB CSR initiative.**

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Today 6.05 pm: GURU VANDANAM- A tribute to Sangita Katanidhi T.K.Govinda Rao by his family & disciples, Madurai T.N.S.Krishna Vocal with L.Ramakrishnan, Srimushnam Raja Rao & Dr.Suresh Vaidyanathan at Youth Hostel, 2nd Avenue, Indira Nagar, Adyar. All Are Welcome..

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Narada Gana Sabha Trust
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M CH-CE

INBRIEF



GCC officials mark Periyar’s birth anniversary with pledge

On the occasion of the 148th birth anniversary of social reformer ‘Periyar’ E.V. Ramasamy, officials and staff of the Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) took the Social Justice Day pledge at the Ripon Buildings on Thursday. Corporation Commissioner G.S. Sameeran paid floral tributes to Periyar’s portrait before leading the pledge. Later in the day, Mr. Sameeran inspected the Chennai Middle School at Gandhi Gramam in Thiruvanniyur. He reviewed the school’s drinking water and toilet facilities, and the implementation of the breakfast programme.

Pay property, professional tax by September 30: Corporation

Property owners and establishments within the Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) limits must pay property tax and professional tax by September 30, the GCC said in a release on Thursday. To facilitate payments, common collection centres at zonal offices and the Revenue Department headquarters at Ripon Buildings will function on September 19, 20, 26 and 27, the release said. Government offices, local bodies, public sector and private companies, and industrial establishments must deduct professional tax from employees’ salaries and remit it to the GCC before the deadline under Section 117 of the Tamil Nadu Urban Local Bodies Act, 1998.

Traffic police to set up 15 centres to help motorists clear pending e-challans

The centres will be open from 9 a.m. to 7 p.m. from September 21 to 30. Personnel will inform motorists about pending challans, send SMS alerts, and provide details to those making inquiries

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Greater Chennai Traffic Police (GCTP) will operate 15 special call centres across the city from September 21 to 30 to help motorists check and clear pending e-challans issued for traffic violations.

The initiative has been launched as several motorists are unaware of e-challans generated through systems such as automatic number plate recognition (ANPR) cameras and the traffic regulation observation zones system. The police said some motorists also hesitate to open links received from the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways, suspecting them to be fraudulent.

The centres will be open from 9 a.m. to 7 p.m. during the 10-day period. Police personnel will contact motorists and inform them about pending challans, send bulk SMS alerts, and provide details to those making inquiries over the



Collection drive: The pending fines can be paid online through the official e-Challan portal or the NextGen e-Challan platform, through Paytm, at post offices, and Tamil Nadu e-Sevai centres. M. SRINATH

phone or in person.

The centres will be set up at ICF Annexure police booth in Ayanavaram, Music Academy police booth in Royapettah, Greenways Junction police booth in Abiramapuram, Tower Clock Junction police booth on Anna Salai, Anna Nagar Roundabout, Anna Arch Traffic police booth, Maduravoyal Traffic police

station, Madhavaram traffic police station near Madhavaram Roundabout, Flower Bazaar, Washermenpet, Pulianthope, R1 Mambalam, and J2 Adyar police stations, Traffic Mount sub-division campus under Kathipara flyover, and ITMS headquarters at the Police Commissioner’s office in Vepery. Motorists can also check

their pending e-challans on the official e-Challan portal or the NextGen e-Challan platform. Pending fines can be paid online through these portals, Paytm, at post offices, and e-Sevai centres. Fines for drunk driving can be paid through the court. Motorists have a week to verify their pending challans and remit the fines.

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Four persons held for robbing bank employee of ₹11 lakh, laptop in T. Nagar

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Four persons were arrested for robbing a 33-year-old private bank employee of ₹11 lakh and a laptop after waylaying him in T. Nagar.

The police said the complainant, A. Karthikeyan, a resident of Boopala Vinayagar Nagar in Kundrathur, was asked by his uncle in Malaysia to collect ₹12 lakh from a person in Parry’s Corner on Tuesday night. He kept ₹1 lakh in his pocket and carried the remaining ₹11 lakh in a bag.

While he was riding his two-wheeler along G.N. Chetty Road near Vani Mahal flyover in T. Nagar, four men travelling on two motorcycles intercepted him. They snatched the bag containing ₹11 lakh and a laptop and fled on their motorcycles.

Based on Karthikeyan’s complaint at the Pondy Bazaar Police Station, the police registered a case and launched an investigation.

They arrested four suspects – Anand Selvan, 39, of Selaiyur, Bablu, 35, of Choolaimedu, Arun Kumar, alias Arnold, 29, of Ti-

The police recovered ₹2.38 lakh of the stolen money and seized a two-wheeler used in the robbery

ruvallur district, and Mohammed Faisal, 29, of Tiruvannamalai district. The police recovered ₹2.38 lakh of the stolen money and seized a two-wheeler allegedly used in the robbery.

Planned robbery

The investigation revealed that the four accused, along with their associates, had planned the robbery and intercepted Karthikeyan knowing that he was carrying the cash.

Anand Selvan had a murder case against him, while Bablu had two cases, one for murder and another for attempt to murder.

Arun Kumar, alias Arnold, was working as an advocate, the police said.

The arrested persons were produced before a court on Thursday after interrogation.

Police said that a search was under way for the other suspects.

Webinar on Alzheimer’s Dementia care to be held on Sept. 20

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Buddhi Clinic and *The Hindu* will host a webinar, “Alzheimer’s Dementia: The Promise of Brain Stimulation,” on September 20 at 11.30 a.m. as part of the events organised to observe World Alzheimer’s Day on September 21.

At the heart of the discussion is an important question: Can stimulating



the brain help preserve cognitive function and change the way Alzheimer’s disease is managed?

Ennapadam S. Krishnamoorthy, Founder, Beha-

vioural Neurologist and Neuropsychiatrist, Buddhi Clinic, will begin by looking at Alzheimer’s disease and dementia beyond the commonly understood symptom of memory loss.

He will discuss why recognising the early signs and arriving at an accurate diagnosis can make a significant difference to care and long-term planning. He will also examine the role of multidisciplinary

assessments, including those undertaken at Buddhi Clinic, and how the treatment landscape is evolving – from symptomatic medications and rehabilitation to newer disease-modifying therapies.

The discussion will then move to one of the emerging frontiers in dementia care: neuromodulation and brain stimulation.

Vivek Misra, Senior Consultant - Neuromodulation

& Clinical Neurosciences, Buddhi Clinic, will explain how Alzheimer’s disease affects not only individual regions of the brain but also the networks that connect them. The webinar will examine where the science stands today, which approaches remain promising but experimental, and how these advances could shape the future of Alzheimer’s care.

The discussion will also

explore how earlier intervention and a more comprehensive approach to treatment could help patients and families navigate an evolving landscape of dementia care.

Athira Elssa Johnson, Senior Reporter, *The Hindu*, will moderate the session. To register, visit newsth.live/THBCAE or scan the QR code



History-sheeter dies at Puzhal Central Prison

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A 30-year-old history-sheeter, who was lodged at the Puzhal Central Prison in connection with a criminal case, died after he developed chest pain in the early hours of Thursday.

The deceased has been identified as P. Silambarasan, alias Tamilarasan, of Kannappar Thidal in Choolai.

According to the police, he was listed as a ‘C’ category history-sheeter with the Chennai Metropolitan Police and had 11 cases pending against him, including criminal intimidation, attempt to murder,

and assault. They said Silambarasan was arrested on September 11 in connection with a criminal case and remanded in judicial custody at Puzhal prison.

Early on Thursday, Silambarasan complained of chest pain, following which the prison personnel took him to the prison hospital.

He was subsequently referred to the Stanley Government Hospital for further treatment. However, doctors declared him brought dead.

The Puzhal police have registered a case and are conducting an inquiry into the circumstances leading to his death.

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CVP & Global Head, Digital Business Services HCLTech

Special Guest
Mr. Prince Jayakumar
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THE HINDU
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INBRIEF



Officials review monsoon preparedness in Perungudi

Northeast monsoon preparedness measures in Perungudi zone were reviewed at a meeting chaired by zonal monitoring officer Maheswari Ravikumar recently. Officials were directed to expedite stormwater drain works, desilting of catch pits, drains, canals, rivers, ponds, and lakes, and removal of water hyacinth. They were also asked to keep pumps ready at locations prone to waterlogging. Officials were asked to ensure basic facilities at 14 relief camps and adequate food stocks at six community kitchens. Greater Chennai Corporation officials and various service departments were directed to complete the works by the end of September.

Text & Context and Health

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (September 18, Friday), the following articles are available:

- What is the Uniform Civil Code debate? [newsth.live/uccdebate](#)
 - Why patient safety needs more than hospital checklists [newsth.live/patientsafety](#)
- You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Parts of T.N. see summer-like temperatures this September

Weak Southwest monsoon and lack of cloud cover cited as factors for sweltering heat; RMC predicts rain, particularly in north and interior parts of T.N., from today will bring relief from heat

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

This September is turning out to be more summer-like in parts of Tamil Nadu, with maximum temperatures remaining above normal in several places.

Officials of the Regional Meteorological Centre (RMC), Chennai, attributed elevated temperatures in the interior parts and coastal areas such as Chennai to the weak Southwest monsoon and lack of cloud cover so far this month. While there have been similar instances at various stations in the past, this September has been unusually hot in many places.

Places such as Erode, Palayamkottai, Vellore, Tiruchi, and Madurai have been among the hottest places in the State this month.

The day temperature has crossed 40°C at some weather stations in these locations earlier this month. On Thursday, several places sizzled with the mercury level soaring to



Unrelenting heat: In Meenambakkam, the highest day temperature measured this month was 38.5°C, which set the record for second-highest temperature this decade in the city. M. SRINATH

4°C or 5°C above normal. For the third consecutive day, Tiruchi recorded the highest day temperature of 39.5°C in the State.

Nungambakkam recorded 38.1°C, making it the decade's second-highest September maximum temperature recorded in the city. The city's all-time September record is 38.9°C, registered in 1883. In Meenambakkam, the highest day temperature measured was 38.5°C this month, which set the record for second-highest temperature this decade in the city. However, the RMC

has predicted a change in weather conditions as increased rainfall activity particularly in north and interior parts of the State would cool down sweltering heat gradually from Friday.

El Niño effect

Officials said El Niño, a global weather phenomenon, had influenced the September weather conditions in Tamil Nadu too.

V.R. Durai, Head, Regional Weather Forecasting Centre, RMC, said the current wet spell would be triggered by a trough ex-

tending up to the Gulf of Mannar and not because of monsoon. It would bring cloud cover and rainfall only to specific regions. The absence of cloud cover and prevailing wind patterns contributed to such high temperatures. The flow of relatively dry southerly winds and lack of adequate thundercloud development sustained the rise in temperature, he said.

With the trough expected to shift its position, rainfall is expected to increase in north Tamil Nadu, including Chennai and Vellore and interior parts, from Friday and bring down the temperature, he said.

Meteorologists said September usually brought considerable rainfall to Tamil Nadu. Y.E.A. Raj, former deputy Director-General of Meteorology, said the break in monsoon conditions with the southwesterly component and wind convergence, which helped thundercloud development, did not occur significantly this season.



Mohamed Rela, chairman, Rela Hospital, and Susannah Schaefer, president and CEO of Smile Train, at the event. M. SRINATH

Rela Hospital launches centre for specialised cleft, craniofacial care

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Rela Hospital, in association with Smile Train, launched a comprehensive Cleft Care Reference Centre (CCRC) on Thursday.

Speaking at the launch event, Mohamed Rela, chairman, Rela Hospital, said the recognition of the cleft and craniofacial care centre at the hospital as a reference centre marked a significant step in their mission to offer comprehensive cleft care. The CCRC will bring together specialists across multiple disciplines to ensure treat-

ment reaches all sections of people, he said.

Susannah Schaefer, president and CEO of Smile Train, said the CCRC would help in building sustainable models of cleft care, which extend beyond individual treatment.

J. Srinisha, managing trustee of Sree Balajee Medical College and Hospital, said the recognition of the CCRC was a significant milestone for the hospital. Syed Altaf Hussain, plastic surgeon and director, CCRC, also spoke on the occasion.

Smile Train is the world's largest cleft-focused organisation.

Three persons arrested in migrant worker murder case

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Three migrant workers were arrested, before they could flee to their native State, in connection with

the murder of a 25-year-old contract worker at Hyundai Mobis near Katramakam on Wednesday.

The deceased, Gulshan Kumar, 25, a native of Bihar, was allegedly attacked

near Nookalathamman Temple by his co-workers following a dispute. The accused have been identified as Topon Doley, 20, Akash Kakholori, 19, and Babu Khan Tumari, 20. Another

accused, identified as Bishash, is also being traced.

During the assault, Doley allegedly restrained Gulshan Kumar while another accused attacked him with a knife, causing a

cut injury to his neck. Gulshan Kumar died in the attack. A team led by Somangalam Inspector traced the accused before they could escape. Further investigation is under way.

GCC identifies 2,079 defunct streetlights across city

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) has identified 2,079 streetlights that were not functioning during a city-wide night inspection recently, Commissioner G.S. Sameeran said.

Following the Commissioner's directions, the inspection was conducted throughout the city on Wednesday to ensure that all 3,11,285 streetlights in the city remain operational. A release said, senior officials were assigned to oversee all 15 zones.

Of the 2,079 non-functioning lights, 850 were located at sites where stormwater drain, Chennai Metro Rail, and Chennai Metropolitan Water Supply and Sewerage Board works were under way. Another 230 were affected by faults in underground power cables, while 999 LED lights were found to be non-functional, the release said.

Temporary streetlights have been installed at locations where service department works are under way. The GCC has initiated measures to restore the 999 LED lights within 24 hours and the 230 lights affected by underground cable faults within 48 hours, it added.

The Commissioner has also directed officials to identify locations where tree branches obstruct streetlight illumination and remove them every week. Branches are being cleared during repair works and at other times as required, the release mentioned. Residents can report non-functioning streetlights through the GCC helpline 1913.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH
OM SHANTHI

K.G. Jagdish Kumar
S/o (Late) Dr. P. Govinda Menon
Passed away on 31/08/2026.
Deeply mourned by loved ones.

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES
9TH DEATH ANNIVERSARY

VIDHYA KUMARAN
Papa, your love and memories remain forever in our hearts.
You are fondly remembered and forever missed
FAMILY & FRIENDS

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES
FIFTH ANNIVERSARY

S. GIRIJA
09.04.1956 - 18.09.2021
Years may pass, but you live in our hearts forever.
Sridhar, Prashanth, Samana, Samyuktha, Janani, Anil & Dhvani

REMEMBRANCE
REMEMBRANCE

ROHINI JANAKIRAMAN
18.09.2025
A year without you and the pain is still fresh.
Our longing grows each day. Yet we feel your grace and love. We miss you Rohu.
Jani, Viji, Vidya, Vijay, Madhu, Sush and Rahul.

IN MEMORY OF YOUR LOVED ONES
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Last Rites : 18.09.2026 (9.00AM - 10.30AM)
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PH: 7299289986 / 9884245234
Grief-stricken Family & Friends

DEEP DEATH CONDOLENCE

Dr. T.M. Durairajan
(1943-2026)
Retired Professor Loyola College
demised on 16.9.26 at 23.15 hrs after a short illness.
His Final rites will be held on 19th Saturday at 8.45 am. at 25, Basha Street, Choolaimedu, Chennai - 600094.
By **WIFE AND DAUGHTERS**

DEATH
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-St. Francis of Assisi
Deeply mourned by family and friends, and the staff of
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Funeral Mass at Annai Valaikanni Shrine, Besant Nagar - Friday, 18th September, 9:30 am.
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GOVERNMENT OF TAMIL NADU
DIRECTORATE OF MEDICAL EDUCATION AND RESEARCH,
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NOTIFICATION
Admission to the following PG Allied Health Science courses for 2026-2027 session
Online filled in applications are invited for admission to PG Allied Health Science courses **M.P.T, Master of Medical Radiology and Imaging Technology, M.O.T, Masters in Nutrition and Dietetics, M.Sc Nuclear Medicine Technology, Master of Optometry (M.Optom), Master of Medical Laboratory science, M.Sc. Molecular Virology, M.Sc Critical Care Technology and M. Sc Neuro Surgical Care courses** for 2026-2027 session.
The details relating to the application fee, eligibility, etc., will be available in the prospectus published in the official website [www.tnmedicalselection.net](#) on 18.09.2026 @ 10.00 AM.

Date of Notification	: 18.09.2026
Date of Commencement of online application	: 18.09.2026 10.00 AM
Last date for online submission of application	: 22.09.2026 upto 5.00 P.M.
Date of Entrance Examination for M.P.T, Master of Medical Radiology and Imaging Technology, M.O.T, Masters in Nutrition and Dietetics, M.Sc Nuclear Medicine Technology, Master of Optometry (M.Optom), and Master of Medical Laboratory science Courses for 2026-2027 session	: 04.10.2026 (Tentatively) Subject to Change

DIPR/ 816 /Display/2026 **DIRECTOR OF MEDICAL EDUCATION & RESEARCH (FAC)**

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SHORT NOTICE

Dated: 17.09.2026

It is intimated that the RIMC Entrance Examination Dec 2026 for the term commencing July 2027 will be conducted through the National Testing Agency (NTA). The online application process for the RIMC Entrance Examination is available at the link (<https://examinationservices.nic.in/Exam Sys 26 Part 2/Root/Home.aspx? enc= Ei4caj BkK1g ZSfgr53lmFQBb9oTMxhET9bNm6zcP2ghS+a59eor30/A 5h2io4z>). The same information is also available on the RIMC website (rimc.edu.in).

Controller of Examinations

DIPR/812/DISPLAY/2026



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e-Procurement Tender Notice (Paper Notification)

TGSPDCL intends to float tenders for Conversion of existing Overhead line to Under-ground cable in various Circles of GHMC Metro Zone area of TGSPDCL on e-procurement platform. For further details of above, please visit <https://tgsouthernpower.org> and www.tender.telangana.gov.in. Phone: 040-23431321

DIPR R.O.No.542-PPICL-AGENCY/ADVT/2026-27 Dt:17-09-2026 Sd/-CHIEF ENGINEER (PROJECTS)

BANARAS LOCOMOTIVE WORKS, VARANASI - 221004

No. GSD/Scrap/Auction Programme/03/2026-27 Dated: 11.09.2026

AUCTION PROGRAMME NOTICE NO.GSD/BLW/SCRAP/03/2026-27

Following is the schedule of e-auction to be held in the month of "October, November & December" 2026 every Wednesday for sale of scrap under the jurisdictions of GSD/BLW, Varanasi.

Types of Auction: e-auction from (10:30 Hrs.), Depot: GSD/BLW/Varanasi, e-auction Date of October-2026 (Wednesday): 7th, 14th, 21st 28th e-auction Date of November-2026 (Wednesday): 4th, 11th, 18th, 25th, e-auction Date of December-2026 (Wednesday): 02nd, 9th, 16th, 23rd, 30th.

You are requested to actively participate in the above scheduled e-auction. For details please visit IREPS website at www.ireps.gov.in.
PRO/BLW/S-26 Dy. CMM/Depot



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Website-www.ner.indianrailways.gov.in
Date- 16.09.2026

Under noted amendment is hereby made against tender No. 30260524 due on 28.08.2026 Tender Notice No. 08 dt. 31.07.2026 (Item No. 45)

Item no.45, Item Description- Tender Opening date with time: Existing Entry: 28.08.2026 11:30 am, Amended as: 28.09.2026 11:30 am.

Item Description- Description: Existing Entry: Existing, Amended as: MDL (Modular) OVM (Over voltage Module), 3 Phase, Part No. A057E698, Suitable for Stamford make alternator.

Description may be viewed at IREPS website. All other terms and condition will be remained unchanged. Note: Above information may be seen on N.E. Railway Website www.ner.indianrailways.gov.in & Govt. of India's website www.tenders.gov.in

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Tel No: 0674-3544751, Fax No: 0674-2395291, Website: www.oscsc.in

Notice inviting e-Auction of Custom Milled Rice(CMR)

RFP Advt. No.16228 / OSCSC Ltd., Date : 17.09.2026

Online Bids are invited exclusively from eligible exporters for the sale/disposal of Custom Milled Rice(CMR) through e-Auction conducted by NCDEX e Markets Limited(NeML) on behalf of Odisha State Civil Supplies Corporation Limited. All interested participants may visit www.oscsc.in & www.neml.in to view and download detailed terms and conditions of the RFP. The last date for registration with NeML and completion of formalities for the e-Auction is 06.10.2026 at 5.00 PM. The date and time of the pre-bid meeting is on dated 30.09.2026 at 11.00 AM at the Office of OSCSC Ltd, C/2 Nayapalli, Bhubaneswar. The changes/amendments (if any) in the RFP document shall be notified on the website mentioned above. The authority of OSCSC Ltd reserves the right to cancel any or the entire auction process without assigning any reason thereof. For more details, please refer to the detailed RFP published on the above websites.

Managing Director
Odisha State Civil Supplies Corporation Limited
7001/119/2627 OIPR-7001/7002/126-27/0010



Odisha State Medical Corporation Limited (OSMCL)
In front of Ram Mandir, Convent Square, Unit-III, Bhubaneswar-751001
Tel.: (0674) 2380950; Website: <https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in> ;
Email: drugs-osmcl@od.gov.in

NOTICE INVITING BID

Bid Ref. No.: OSMCL/2026-27/DRUGS-DHS-GEN-GR-III/05 Date : 18/09/2026

Online Bids through e-Tender portal (<https://tenders.odisha.gov.in>) are invited from eligible bidders for Supply of Drugs & Medical Consumables as per the particulars mentioned below :

Sl. No.	Particulars	Date and time
1.	Date & time of release of bid	18/09/2026, 3 PM
2.	Date & time for submission of queries by E-Mail id - drugs-osmcl@od.gov.in	22/09/2026, up to 5:00 PM
3.	Date & time of Online bid submission	Start Date & Time 28/09/2026, 3 PM End Date & Time 26/10/2026, 6.00 PM
4.	Date & time for submission of Tender Documents, Tender Document Fee and EMD amount as per section-IV of tender document.	Start Date & Time 27/10/2026, 10 AM End Date & Time 03/11/2026, 11.00 AM
5.	Date & time of Online Technical bid Opening	03/11/2026, 11:30 AM
6.	Date of opening of Price Bid	To be informed to the qualified bidders

The bid document with all information relating to the bidding process including cost of bid document, EMDs, Prequalification criteria and terms & conditions are available in the websites: <https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in> and <https://tenders.odisha.gov.in>. The Authority reserves the right to accept / reject any part thereof or all the bids without assigning any reason thereof. All notice will be published in the OSMCL website <https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in>. Hence the bidders are requested to visit OSMCL website <https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in> time to time for any published notice against the tender.

Sd/-
Managing Director, OSMCL Ltd., Odisha
10001/550/2627 OIPR-10001/10112/126-27/0010



WEST CENTRAL RAILWAY

OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE, DATE: 15.09.2026

Sr. DEN/CO/WCR, Bhopal acting for and on behalf of the President of India, invites E-Tenders against following works, upto 15.30 hours on the dates mentioned against tenders. The complete tender document and detailed information regarding tender is available on the website <http://www.ireps.gov.in>. NIT can also be seen on the notice board of DRM (W)/WCR/Bhopal office. Manual offers are not allowed against these tenders. For any correction in these tenders, if necessary, corrigendum will be uploaded on website prior to tender opening date and copy of corrigendum will be pinned on Notice Board of this office, which may be seen upto the date of tender opening. Tenderers are requested to offer their rates and submit tenders according to the provisions of GST ACT 2017. (1) NIT No. WCR-BPL-W:- 26-27-W-18-100, Date: 10.09.2026, Name of work including Location: Guna-Gwalior Section: Through Rail Renewal TRR (P) at Part A) Km 1124.9, 1134.267, Km 1138.43-1142.0 & Km 1143.5-1161.1, Part B) Km 1161.1-1169.1 & Km 1170.8-1192.8 and Part C) Km 1192.8-1194.6, Km 1226.4-1229.0, Km 1260.1-1267.2, Km 1281.1-1287.0, Km 1288.2-1290.0 & Km 1292.7-1293.4, Total 77.437 Km under ADEN/Shivpuri section. Published cost of tender: ₹93958935.58/- Earnest Money: ₹ 1879200/- Completion Period: 18 Months Last date for submitting tender: 06.10.2026 (2) NIT No. WCR-BPL-W:- 26-27-W-19-101, Date: 10.09.2026, Name of work including Location: Guna-Gwalior Section: Through Rail Renewal TRR (P) at Part A) Km 1196.4-1226.4, Part B) Km 1229.0-1256.6 & Km 1277.8-1281.5 and Part C) Km 1298.0-1311.950, Total 75.25 Km under ADEN/Shivpuri section. Published cost of tender: ₹93005966.88/- Earnest Money: ₹ 1860100/- Completion Period: 18 Months Last date for submitting tender: 06.10.2026 (3) NIT No. WCR-BPL-W:- 26-27-W-20-102, Date: 10.09.2026, Name of work including Location: Annual Maintenance Contract including supply of spares for EEC Make 10 nos. Model No. DIGISCAN DS 322 AT. Sr. No. DS39LS, DS40LS, DS41LS, DS42LS, DS44LS, DS45LS, DS46LS, DS47LS, DS 97LU and DS 98LU working weld Tester USFD Machines in Bhopal Division of West Central Railway for a period of 2 years. Published cost of tender: ₹2517530.00/- Earnest Money: ₹ 50400/- Completion Period: 24 Months Last date for submitting tender: 06.10.2026 (4) NIT No. WCR-BPL-W:- 26-27-S-17-103, Date: 11.09.2026, Name of work including Location: Miscellaneous P/Way repairs and maintenance of track under SS E/P. Way/M/ET Published cost of tender: ₹7497231.8/- Earnest Money: ₹1500000/- Completion Period: 12 Months Last date for submitting tender: 05.10.2026 (5) NIT No. WCR-BPL-W:- 26-27-N-31-104, Date: 12.09.2026, Name of work including Location: White wash, colour wash, special repair and maintenance zone for all residential and service buildings under the Jurisdiction of SSE/Works/BINA as per DSR 2023 costing upto Rs. 5 lakhs each, for the year 2026-27 under ADEN/M/BINA Published cost of tender: ₹8605200.00/- Earnest Money: ₹ 172100/- Completion Period: 9 Months Last date for submitting tender: 05.10.2026 (6) NIT No. WCR-BPL-W:- 26-27-N-32-105, Date: 12.09.2026, Name of work including Location: White wash, colour wash, special repair and maintenance zone for all residential and service buildings under the Jurisdiction of SSE/Works/GUNA as per DSR 2023 costing upto Rs. 5 lakhs each, for the year 2026-27 under ADEN/M/GUNA. Published cost of tender: ₹8605200.00/- Earnest Money: ₹ 172100/- Completion Period: 9 Months Last date for submitting tender: 05.10.2026

DRM/W

West Central Railway, Bhopal

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Office of the Chief Engineer
Design, Master Planning & Hydrology
(Water Resource Department)
Jal Bhawan Room No.-203, Doranda, Ranchi-834002
Email- cedesign-wrd-jhr@nic.in

Letter No.-S.E./Dam & Gate/SDSO/335-VII/2026Ranchi/Dated-.....

Notice Inviting Application (for Willingness) from Domain Experts for Empanelment of Members for Independent Panel of Experts (IPOE) to Conduct Comprehensive Dam Safety Evaluation (CDSE) of Specified Dams under WRD Jharkhand

In light of Chapter IX, Section 38, 39 and 40 of Dam Safety Act 2021, NDSA Regulation No. 407, Dated 23.05.2025 and Government of Jharkhand Resolution No. 3/P.M.C/Misc/757/2026-371 dated 29.06.26, Water Resources Department, Govt. of Jharkhand intends to select members for **Independent Panel of Experts (IPOE)**, which shall consist of 8 (eight) domain experts.

The structure of each IPOE shall be as under:

SL No.	DESIGNATION	DOMAIN OF EXPERTISE
1	Member	Dam Safety Expert
2	Member	Design Expert
3	Member	Construction Supervision Expert
4	Member	Geologist
5	Member	Hydrologist
6	Member	Hydro mechanical Expert
7	Member	Instrumentation Expert
8	Member	Seismic Expert

1. The expected prerequisite qualifications of domain experts are as described in NDSA Regulation No. 407, Dated 23.05.2025 attached with this Notice Inviting Applications. (Details are available on the link provided in the website- wrd.jharkhand.gov.in)

2. Relevant Terms and conditions pertaining to the functioning of each IPOE are mentioned in Government of Jharkhand Resolution No.3/P.M.C/Misc/757/2026-371 dated 29.06.26. (Details are available on the link provided in the website- wrd.jharkhand.gov.in)

3. The Terms of Reference, describing the roles and responsibilities, remunerations etc. are as mentioned. (Details are available on the link provided in the website- wrd.jharkhand.gov.in)

4. Applications are invited from all interested and eligible domain experts.

5. Application form in prescribed format is attached. (Details are available on the link provided in the website- wrd.jharkhand.gov.in)

6. Applicants may find this Notice inviting Applications on the website: wrd.jharkhand.gov.in under the link "What's New!"

7. Experts currently working under Central Government Institutions, State Government Institutions, Public Sector Undertakings, Indian Institute of Technology, National Institute of Technology, Recognized Private Institutions, Reputed Independent Experts along with Retired Officers holding requisite qualifications may apply.

8. The duly filled application form in prescribed format along with updated CVs including self-attested copies of proof of age, qualification and experience should be submitted through registered post/ speed post / courier / in person to the Office of Chief Engineer, Design, Master Planning and Hydrology, Jal Bhawan, Doranda, Ranchi- 834002 OR it may also be submitted online on the email ID – cedesign-wrd-jhr@nic.in.

9. All applications must be submitted to the above mentioned address/email ID by 30.09.2026 before 5:00 pm.

10. The applicants must present the original documents for proof of age, qualification and experience when the Department may require during verification of prerequisite credentials.

11. The date of interview will be intimated later. Applicant may appear in physical or virtual mode. The Applicants must intimate the undersigned beforehand about the mode in which they wish to attend the interview. The interview in physical mode will be conducted in Conference Room, 1st Floor, Nepal House Secretariat, Doranda, Ranchi. For those applicants who wish to attend the interview in virtual mode, a link will be sent through email to the candidates.

12. The list of finally selected experts shall be uploaded on the website wrd.jharkhand.gov.in and each successful applicant shall also be intimated separately on their email.

13. The cost of conveyance and logistics for submitting the form or attending interview shall not be borne by Water Resources Department, GOJ.

PR 389927 Water Resource(26-27)#D

Chief Engineer
Design, Master Planning & Hydrology,
Jal Bhawan, Doranda, Ranchi- 834002

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Does the BRICS summit signify a shift for Indian foreign policy?



Ajay Bisaria
served as High Commissioner to Pakistan and Canada and is the author of 'Anger Management: The Troubled Diplomatic Relationship Between India and Pakistan'

PARLEY

With a strong pushback against unilateral western sanctions; criticism of Israel over the killing of civilians, the attacks on Lebanon, and the forced occupation of Palestinian territory; and support for UN reform as well as a BRICS payment mechanism, the New Delhi Declaration of 2026 has been likened to India's foreign policy from its non-aligned past. But was it a compromise by New Delhi to build consensus, or will the statement, and Prime Minister Narendra Modi's close engagement with the leaders of Iran, Russia, and China, have a bearing on India's foreign policy? Ajay Bisaria and Happymon Jacob discuss the question in a conversation moderated by **Suhasini Haidar**.

Is the New Delhi declaration a return to non-alignment or just momentary rhetoric?

Ajay Bisaria: Broadly, the declaration is in keeping with India's foreign policy, whether that is strategic autonomy and multi-alignment or multi-vector engagement. In terms of optics, India is more on the front foot and less apologetic than it used to be. India is getting more and more comfortable in a non-western forum, saying that it is emphatically part of it. While it doesn't necessarily mean a shift in posture, it does suggest a greater degree of comfort with a different set of optics.

Happymon Jacob: The BRICS summit is under spotlight and things under spotlight look bigger and shinier than they really are. BRICS is a political platform; not a security platform. I don't think India's policy today is that of non-alignment at all. Non-alignment was a strategy for a weak state in a bipolar world. Today, we are in a different kind of world and the desire in India is to become one of the poles in a multipolar world. There is a reference to the Bandung Spirit (Non-Aligned Movement) in the BRICS declaration in pursuit of a fairer, more inclusive, and representative multilateral system. But that is nostalgia, not real policy.

How important are optics such as the Modi-Xi-Putin handshakes or the Prime Minister reaching out to the Iranian President at a time when these leaders represent the “anti-Western lobby”?

HJ: The optics are, in some ways, the substance here. Chinese President Xi Jinping had not been to India in nearly seven years. And we had the Abu Dhabi Crown Prince (Khaled bin Zayed Al Nahyan) sitting at the same table. In some ways, the photograph is the message. At the BRICS



Russia's President Vladimir Putin, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, and China's President Xi Jinping pose with other leaders during the BRICS Summit. AFP

outreach session, a lot of powers who don't otherwise get into great power conversations were present. So, there was a lot of socialisation happening inside the platform and on its margins. But I think we should understand that this is not really having an impact on how the world is being shaped. The declaration calls for exercising restraint and protecting civilians and civilian infrastructure and pointedly recalls the respective national positions of each member. It is fantastic, but the argument here is about optics, not common positions.

AB: I would agree that these multilateral fora are often performative to a degree and therefore all optics matter. But in a multilateral document, you can say the silent part aloud; what a country won't say in a national statement, it can say aloud in a high-level multilateral summit. For instance, everyone knows that the phrase “unilateral coercive measures” is about U.S. actions. So, you're not really saying we condemn U.S. action on so-and-so date; you're simply saying that we are against U.S. tariffs and [western] sanctions. There is an understanding now that what is said in a multilateral document can be different from a national position.

Every BRICS summit since 2022, including the 2024 summit in Russia, has made a reference to Ukraine. The New Delhi Declaration is the first time that references to Ukraine have been dropped. Why?

AB: My guess would be that it was a Russian veto. In the Rio BRICS declaration last year, there was even condemnation of a Ukrainian attack on Russia without an equivalent condemnation of anything Russia had done. So this time, instead of just condemning Ukraine, they might have decided to drop the whole thing entirely. It is very disappointing that a major multilateral geopolitical forum doesn't call for belligerents to end the war, but instead stays silent. That is an error of omission. I suspect the



Broadly, the Delhi declaration is in keeping with India's foreign policy, whether that is strategic autonomy and multi-alignment or multi-vector engagement

AJAY BISARIA

Russians said, no, we don't accept it, and in the interest of having a consensus, it was dropped.

HJ: I think India has no particular reason to push for that language to be present in the declaration because we have quite clearly sided with the Russian Federation in this war, indirectly if not directly. There must have been Russian push but I see no reason why there could not have been some neutral language to put in [references to Ukraine], given the precedent (of previous BRICS joint declarations).

The condemnation of Israel in the statement is very strong. Does this represent a shift for India given the PM's speech on standing “shoulder to shoulder” with Israel during his visit in February 2026?

AB: The big picture is that India is trying to establish neutral and balanced positions on both conflicts, and therefore not be seen as backing only one side in either. It has taken safety in the language of the United Nations. There's a specific mention of the UN Security Council Resolution 2803 of November last year, which spoke about an International Stabilisation Force and a Board of Peace. Some of the language has been drawn from there. The overall posture is: let's try to be balanced and reasonably neutral.

HJ: There is a clear disjunction between the statement and what Prime Minister Modi told the Israeli parliament. Perhaps the declaration is in some way intended to counter the perception that India was getting too close to Israel. The two-state solution has always been India's position, so the declaration doesn't contradict Indian policy there. But with the UAE, Egypt, Iran, and Indonesia in the room, there was only so much India could do to push back against the harshness of that language. What Prime Minister Modi told the Israelis in Israel is emotional and consequential. But what is written in the BRICS Declaration is multilateral, symbolic, and not very consequential. I would still say the balance is tilted in favour of Israel as a partner.

How significant are the paragraphs on economic issues, particularly on intra-BRICS trade using payments in national currencies? These 10 or 11 countries represent 40% of the

global economy, and 25% of global trade. Could they pose a challenge to the G7?

HJ: Indian policy has two parts. One is the support for local currency payment mechanisms. I don't think India has supported a permanent payment mechanism under the ambit of BRICS. I think there is an acknowledgement that there is no one-size-fits-all approach as far as currency settlement payment mechanisms are concerned. I would think twice before signing on to a non-U.S. dollar payment mechanism, which I believe will mean the next big currency or the next powerful currency. And unfortunately, China's currency is going to be that big currency.

AB: BRICS is a counterpoint to the G7, an economic grouping that also has geopolitical responsibilities. But I think India also finds itself at an intersection with the G7, because it is a sort of permanent invitee to the G7, along with Australia and South Korea. I have made the argument elsewhere that the G7 should dissolve itself and become the Democratic 10 (D10), including these three countries. I think that is the real strategic autonomy or multi-vector engagement, where India becomes the bridge between the east and the west, but also a voice of the south.

Will any of the decisions at BRICS see their way into future Indian foreign policy? Or is this just one moment with BRICS countries?

AB: I think this is a moment of success in Indian diplomacy in terms of conducting a major international event. In November, there will be another opportunity to meet global leaders at the ASEAN-East Asia Summit in the Philippines, followed by Prime Minister Modi's visits to the U.S., Canada, and Brussels, where he could potentially secure three trade agreements. I think that's what diplomacy will be about: multi-vector engagement; keeping all stakeholders engaged, in multiple directions.

HJ: India has only so much diplomatic capital. Therefore, it is important to pick our battles, forums, and partners. I think we should be present in those rooms where global rules on AI are being framed, and where the future of space governance is discussed. I don't think the next world order is going to be made in forums such as the BRICS but in those silent small rooms.



To listen to the full interview
Scan the code or go to the link
www.thehindu.com

NOTEBOOK

AI makes editors read the writer as well as the text

Editors are often caught between their duty to the readers and employers and the demands of the publishing process

Vasudevan Mukunth

I'm a commissioning editor. Every day, I receive more submissions of articles written by AI than the last. The same goes for articles polished by AI. More than going against *The Hindu's* policy, this habit has the potential to corrode the human practice of writing.

Writing is often hard. You consider the relationship between your intentions and the meaning of words laid down on a page. You think through using the many degrees of freedom a sentence or paragraph affords to convey precisely what you mean, down to the feeling, while also holding readers' attention and doing justice to yourself without becoming self-absorbed. Writing should trouble the mind. AI-made or -polished writing offers to take this trouble away – a temptation to be resisted.

AI-written or -polished text can be corrosive to readers as well because all such texts, no matter how diverse their contents, read the same way. Editing it to be more human, to have an undulating rhythm rather than that sterilised glaze, is also an exasperating experience.

I used to maintain a list of the hallmarks of AI-written or -polished text, but as they evolved, I turned to two 'detector' tools: GPTZero and Pangram. I trust them because of their favourable coverage in the scientific press, their developers' attitude towards the tools' role in the publishing enterprise, and their lower false-positive rates. A false positive is when a tool flags a piece as being AI-written when in reality it is not. It can be pernicious because it causes me to decline a submission I may have accepted, potentially disappointing an author. Such a result may also cause editors to develop an unfavourable opinion of such contributors.

Sometimes, these tools jointly return very high or very low scores, allowing me to decide quickly about accepting or declining submissions. The problem arises when one or both tools return a middling score, e.g. “50% chance of being written by AI” or “50% of the text is written by AI”.

In these instances, I need to negotiate a way forward. If the author is a rookie, I may insist on seeing the timestamped version history of the document containing their text, and ensure the words didn't suddenly appear all at once. (If I have doubts at the time of commissioning itself, I may insist the author quote some experts firsthand and submit their reporting notes together with the finished article.) If I have a mature relationship with an author, I directly communicate the stakes and possible courses of action.

But when an author doesn't tick these convenient boxes, I need to draft a reply that balances several sensibilities. First, I must not offend them. In fact, I have no intention of villainising them: people use AI models with text for various reasons, only a small subset of which are malicious. Second, I need to elicit from the author an honest response about whether, and if so how, they used AI – especially a reply I can be sure is unencumbered by insecurities or second-guessing. Third, I need to keep the author's trust while maintaining that I cannot accept AI-written or -polished text. Fourth, I must justify, if required, my decision to repose my trust in those tools rather than in my judgment and/or in our relationship alone.

Now, if GPTZero and Pangram independently falsely flag 5 out of every 100 articles as being AI-written or -polished, they will have a combined false positive rate of just 1 in 4 million. However, the chance of one tool flagging an article right and the other flagging it wrong is still 1 in 1,000, which is much higher.

But I cannot make decisions with mathematics alone as my guide. AI has caused me to think more closely about the author submitting an article and their reasons to use – or not use – AI. Similarly, it would help if authors think more closely about editors, who are caught between their duty to their readers and employers on one hand and to facilitate the publishing process on the other.

mukunth.v@thehindu.co.in

PICTURE OF THE WEEK

Chasing the sunset



Golden hour: Trained swimmers accompany a Ganesha idol which is to be immersed in the Krishna River downstream of the Prakasam Barrage in Vijayawada, Andhra Pradesh following the Ganesh Chaturthi festivities on September 16. The immersion was carried out at a designated stretch of the river. G.N. RAO

FROM THE ARCHIVES

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 18, 1976

Bright future for computers in India

Hyderabad, September 17: Prof. A.S. Douglas, Professor of Computational Methods, London School of Economics and Vice-President, International Federation of Information Processing told *The Hindu* here to-day that computer technology would have considerable future in developing countries like India as it aided the planning process in various spheres. He said that computers could be used for highly sophisticated calculations in

The Hindu.

scientific and technical matters as well as simple calculations in physics and chemistry.

Prof. Douglas said that while there were certain jobs which could be done efficiently by men, there were many things which computers could perform more efficiently and quickly than human beings. It was necessary that a happy balance should be maintained in the choice of jobs that could be performed by men and those that could be entrusted to computers.

Prof. Douglas, who was delivering a lecture under the auspices of the Hyderabad Chapter of the Computer Society of India, said that India should have a well-organised programme for the training of personnel needed for manning the computers.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 18, 1926

A lecture on advertising

Under the auspices of the Students' Economical Association the inaugural address was delivered yesterday evening by Prof. Jospeh France of the Presidency College, in the Senate House. The meeting was well attended. The Chairman in his opening remarks said that India was lacking in the art of advertisements. Owing to the neglect of this branch of study most of the Indian industries were not well-known. Best of their products found no place in the advertising field, whereas they found so many minor products of the west advertised through newspapers.

From Page One

U.S. passes Bill targeting Russian energy sector

The issue had been discussed with various U.S. interlocutors at high levels, the Ministry statement said, adding that the government made it clear to the U.S. that the sanctions would have implications for the bilateral relationship and energy markets.

The Trump administration had announced an additional 25% tariff, on top of an existing 25% tariff on India in July 2025, for the purchase of Russian oil. The share of Russian crude oil in Indian oil imports fell to its lowest level in two years in December 2025, but energy markets have been under additional pressure owing to the U.S.-Iran conflict and New Delhi's import of Russian oil hit an 11-month high in April this year. However, the U.S. Treasury paused sanctions for oil shipments that were in transit before March 11, 2026, as supplies were hit following the start of the conflict in West Asia on February 28.

“To China and India: You better clean up your act. Buy your oil and gas somewhere else,” said Senator Richard Blumenthal, a Connecticut Democrat, shortly after the Bill was passed.

Potential target countries

Countries that would be potential targets for the tariff are the top five “largest importers, by total volume” of Russian-origin crude oil or natural gas in the 12 months preceding the date of enactment of the law, and have knowingly made new purchases of Russian crude oil on or after 30 days from the date the Bill becomes law.

A country that is among the top five countries “facilitating Russian oil sanctions evasion” would also be eligible for the tariffs of up to 100%.

Countries that have taken significant steps to reduce their Russian natural gas imports or whose gas imports were less than 15% of Russia's total gas export, would be exempt from the sanctions.

A House amendment proposed by Democrat Steny Hoyer that sought to name the top 10 importers – China, India, Turkiye, Azerbaijan, Hungary, Slovakia, the UAE and the Kyrgyz Republic – had not passed into the final version considered on Wednesday.

Sweeping powers

The Bill, named after Senator Lindsey Graham , a prominent supporter of Ukraine, who died suddenly on July 11 this year, had passed the Senate 86-11 on August 7. Several prominent Democrats, like Elizabeth Warren and those caucusing with Democrats like Bernie Sanders, as well as some Republicans, such as Rand Paul, had opposed the Bill, concerned over the sweeping powers it would give the President or the cost it would impose, via tariffs, on Americans.

Declared dead, workers come back to get ration

This damning indictment, found in the draft information system audit report on ‘Implementation of PARESHRAM and Nirman Shramik Portal in the State’, is expected to be part of the Comptroller and Auditor General's Audit report for the financial year 2024-2025.

“This implies the beneficiary was alive and authenticating her Aadhaar physically to avail ration indicating fraudulent disbursement of death benefit. Further, it also indicates that medical officers issued death certificates against alive persons,” the draft report says.

Subu R., the Principal Accountant General (Audit-1) of Odisha, had sent the draft report to Chithira Arumugam, then Additional Chief Secretary to the Labour and ESI Department, soliciting her response on the massive anomalies indicating corruption in the implementation of the Nirman Shramik scheme. A copy of the draft report has been obtained by *The Hindu*.

Construction workers welfare scheme

Under the Nirman Shramik scheme, building and construction workers between ages of 18 and 60 years who have completed at least 90 days of work in the preceding 12 months and are not enrolled in any other welfare fund are eligible for registration under the Building and Other Construction Workers (Regulation of Employment and Conditions of Service) Act, 1996. Once registered, workers are entitled to various welfare benefits including educational scholarships for their children, assistance for marriage, maternity, and funeral expenses, and death compensation.

A nominee is entitled to ₹2 lakh as a death benefit and ₹5,000 as funeral assistance upon the death of an eligible registered worker. All financial assistance is paid from the dedicated fund of the Building and Other Construction Workers' Welfare Board, which collects a cess of 1% of the construction cost incurred by an employer. The board had accumulated more than ₹4,000 crore by 2024.

Analysis across databases

“On cross analysis of the NFSA data, audit observed that 3,013 death beneficiaries under Nirman Shramik scheme were also beneficiaries under NFSA. In 914 cases, discrepancy was also observed in the name of worker under Nirman Shramik with that of person registered under NFSA having same Aadhaar. Hence, disbursal of death benefits to those persons having difference in name updated in Aadhaar was abnormal,” the audit points out.

Auditors have also analysed the database and cross verified this information with the Odisha Birth Death Registration System data provided by the Odisha Computer Application Centre.

PM pitches India as a global destination for chipmaking

The country's success in the critical industry would strengthen supply chain of entire world, says Modi; 1 lakh technicians to be trained over five years for employment in factories, adds IT Minister

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi pitched India as a “new and trustworthy location” for electronics manufacturing, urging global chipmakers to consider the country's potential to relieve electronics from the “weaponisation” of supply chains.

“This is not a sector where you set up a factory and the job is done,” said Mr. Modi, who inaugurated Semicon India 2026. “Wherever semiconductor ecosystems have been built in the world, the entire ecosystem has come together only after decades of hard work. But India, with your cooperation, has worked simultaneously on chip design, manufacturing, equipment manufacturing, the materials ecosystem, testing capability, and has demonstrated success.”

The Prime Minister's address came days after the India Semiconductor Mission's (ISM) second phase, which has an outlay of ₹1.27 lakh crore, was notified.

Describing India as the



High potential: Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw at SEMICON India in New Delhi on Thursday. ANI

“mother of democracy”, he said, “When such a country succeeds in a critical industry, it strengthens the supply chain of the entire world. And today, when supply chains are being weaponised, its importance becomes much greater. We should also look at this development taking place in India from this larger perspective.”

Semicon India 2026 brought together semiconductor and electronics firms from India and other countries. Speaking at the event, IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said the govern-

ment plans to train one lakh people who will be a “global pool of talent” and can “straightaway be employed in the factories which are coming up in India”.

Mr. Vaishnaw said the government would target at least 200 start-ups and firms in ISM 2.0's chip design pillar, almost double of what was done for the first phase.

The Minister added that the government was committed to training more than one lakh technicians over the coming five years for different electronics

manufacturing duties.

Global industry body SEMI's CEO Ajit Manocha estimated that the semiconductor industry would cross \$1.3 trillion this year, and \$2 trillion by 2030.

Leaders from the semiconductor industry expressed hope in India's trajectory and its role in their global plans. Applied Materials committed to invest \$5 billion over the coming five years to expand its R&D centre and supply chain.

“Earlier this year, we began commercial production at Sanand,” Micron CEO Sanjay Mehrotra said. “Our current production capacity already exceeds the memory required for India's entire laptop market ... The India Semiconductor Mission, and now ISM 2.0, gave this industry a foundation it did not have before.”

Infineon CEO Jochen Hanebeck called India a “market of tremendous importance”, praising the “pace of progress across the Indian ecosystem”. Pointing to his firm increasing hiring in India by 28%, he said that there was great potential for India in the sector.

Plea flagging issues in Delhi SIR to get ‘precedence’ in SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday agreed to give “precedence” in hearing to a writ petition raising discrepancies in the conduct of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the electoral roll in Delhi, including the removal of lakhs of voters from the draft roll for nebulous reasons.

“We will list it on Monday. Such matters will have precedence,” Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant said.

The CJI was reacting to an oral mentioning by advocates Prashant Bhushan and Neha Rathi of a petition filed by activists Anjali Bhardwaj and Amrita Johri.

The plea flagged that apart from the more than 47 lakh names that have been removed as per the draft roll, the Election Commission (EC) was preparing notices to 33 lakh people on two grounds: logical discrepancies and mapping.

“Out of 97,53,577 electors who are listed on the draft Delhi SIR roll after the enumeration phase, 33,12,919 electors (33.96%) are being issued notices af-

The petition said the EC has not defined ‘logical discrepancies’ or laid guidelines to categorise them

ter being identified for either having no mapping (13,79,785) or for logical discrepancies (19,33,134). However, the petitioners (Election Commission and the Chief Electoral Officer, Delhi) have failed to publish the list of electors to whom notices have been issued along with the specific basis thereof, contrary to the procedure,” the petition said.

The petition said the term ‘logical discrepancies’ has neither been defined by the EC nor has any specific criteria to determine the circumstances in which an elector would fall within that category.

In the West Bengal SIR, ‘logical discrepancies’ could include anything from improbable family age gaps and changing parent names to entries backed by only Aadhaar. ‘Mapping’ meant the exercise of verifying voters’ details with earlier records or their families’ generational voting data.

Noel Tata opposes bid for Chandrasekaran's return

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Noel Tata, chairman of Tata Trusts, which holds a 66% stake in Tata Sons, on Thursday voted against the reappointment of N. Chandrasekaran as chairman of Tata Sons.

Meanwhile, four Board members – Venu Srinivasan, Harish Manwani, Saurabh Agarwal and Anita M. George – approved the reappointment.

The Board also resolved to initiate steps to comply with RBI guidelines and decided to seek guidance from the RBI, Tata Trusts and other stakeholders on applicable compliance requirements.

On Saturday, the RBI rejected Tata Sons' application to de-register its Core Investment Company NBFC licence and directed it to immediately comply with listing regulations.

Tata Sons said the Board had received from Tata Trusts its unanimous resolution, dated July 28, 2025, expressing its appreciation of Mr. Chandrasekaran “for his stewardship of the Group from 2017 onwards”.

“In recognition of these efforts, the Tata Trusts resolved that he be re-appointed as Executive Chairman for a further term of five years upon the expiry of his current term. Subsequently, in September 2025, the Board of Tata Sons agreed in principle to re-appoint Mr. Chandrasekaran as Executive Chairman for a further term of five years,” it said in a statement.

“Pursuant to applicable provisions of law, the Board decided to obtain the relevant formal approval in February 2026. But in the absence of unanimity, the resolution was deferred for decision. In subsequent Board meetings in May 2026 and June 2026, this matter was discussed but was not resolved,” the company said.

In view of the above, on August 12, Mr. Chandrasekaran, in a letter, had opted



Noel Tata

not to offer himself for re-appointment. On September 3, the Nomination and Remuneration Committee (NRC) of the Board, comprising Mr. Srinivasan, Mr. Manwani and Ms. George, met to discuss the re-appointment.

“After due deliberation and in recognition of his contributions and the larger interests of the Tata Group, the NRC unanimously resolved to request him to reconsider his decision and to recommend him for re-appointment at the next Board meeting,” the statement said.

‘Duly accepted’

As Mr. Chandrasekaran decided to revisit his decision not to seek re-appointment, the Tata Trusts reiterated its position that the decision has been “duly accepted and has attained finality”.

“On 12 August 2026, Mr. Chandrasekaran communicated to the Tata Sons Board, his own decision not to offer himself for reappointment – a decision that was freely taken, clearly expressed and not the outcome of any process of review. It was made public without prior intimation or any deliberations with the shareholders of the company. Once such a decision has been publicly communicated, it has consequences which cannot be afterwards undone, since the Group's employees, its lenders and counterparties, the market and the majority shareholder have all proceeded on it,” Tata Trusts said.

Tata Trusts said it formally placed on record its acceptance of the decision

the following day and advised Tata Sons to initiate the process for setting up a selection committee for appointing a successor, in accordance with the Articles of Association of Tata Sons.

“The Trusts’ position remains unchanged, as a considered judgement of a majority shareholder. This position was reiterated in today's board meeting by the Chairman, Tata Trusts. The resolution seeking to reappoint Mr. Chandrasekaran in the Board meeting today, with four Directors voting in favour, and Mr. Noel Tata against, was a legal nullity in view of the provisions of the Articles of Association of Tata Sons,” it said.

At the Board meeting, Mr. Tata submitted a legal opinion obtained from Justice D.Y. Chandrachud, former Chief Justice of India, regarding the correctness of the Trusts’ stand. “The same was not taken note of by the Board,” Tata Trusts said.

On the Board's decision to follow the RBI's order, Tata Trusts has asked Tata Sons to explore options other than listing and save the ‘Tata model’.

At the Board meeting, Mr. Tata, said, “Tata Group was conceived as a national service carried on through business and has conducted itself so in this manner for over a century. The structure of its ownership is what has allowed it to remain so and has permitted Tata Sons to act repeatedly in ways that a purely commercial calculus would not have supported.”

Mr. Tata proposed providing liquidity to the SP Group, which holds little more than 18% stake in Tata Sons and had been asking for listing. The proposal was received from the Shapoorji Pallonji (SP Group) regarding monetisation of a portion of their Tata Sons shareholding held by Sterling Investments Corporation Private Limited and Cyrus Investments Private Limited.

The Hindu Bureau
JAMMU

Two Pakistani Jaish-e-Mohammed terrorists were killed and a suspect was detained in an anti-terror operation in Jammu division's Udhampur district on Thursday.

The Jammu & Kashmir Police identified the two dead terrorists as Saddam and Mustafa. “An AK assault rifle (with four magazines), M4 carbine (with three magazines), a Glock pistol (with two magazines), and four grenades have been recovered from them,” said the police.

The Army launched ‘Operation Sohan’ during the intervening night of September 16 and 17 following “confirmed inputs indicat-



Security officials arrest a suspect for his alleged association with two Jaish-e-Mohammad terrorists in Udhampur on Thursday. ANI

ing the presence of terrorists in Udhampur”.

“Despite hostile weather, difficult terrain and poor visibility, troops of the Army's White Knight Corps, J&K Police and CRPF launched a targeted counter-terrorism operation, resulting in the neutralisation of two terrorists,” said the Army. The arrested suspect is being questioned.

“The operation is still in progress, with search and surveillance operations continuing in the area. Security forces remain deployed to track and neutralise any remaining threat,” the Army said.

Court issues arrest warrant against LeT commander

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

A special court of the National Investigation Agency (NIA) in Jammu has issued a non-bailable arrest warrant against Pakistan-based Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) commander Saifullah, linked to several major attacks in Jammu and Kashmir, including the 2025 Pahalgam attack.

“Keeping in view the fact that the accused person is at large and the investigating agency has not been able to procure his attendance in the ordinary manner. As such a general warrant of arrest (non-bailable) is issued against Saifullah,” reads the order.

The NIA has mentioned the name of Saifullah in the case as one “operating from Pakistan and providing weapons, funds and directions to terrorists in the Kashmir Valley”. The agency said it had busted a LeT module earlier in the year.

Kuki-Zo Council warns of full-fledged agitation if demands are not met

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Kuki-Zo Council (KZC) has threatened to launch a “full-fledged agitation” if the Centre fails to address its administrative, humanitarian, and security concerns by October 10, 2026. The organisation accused the National Investigation Agency (NIA) of selective operations against the community.

The KZC said the Kuki-Zo people were facing sev-

ere shortages of food and essential commodities in Kamjong, Kangpokpi, Non-ey, and Tamenglong districts due to an economic blockade imposed by the United Naga Council.

The Council said innocent civilians were frequently summoned by NIA for questioning, but “fewer operations appear to be conducted in Naga and Meitei areas”.

It demanded the re-imposition of President's Rule in Manipur.



APPEAL

Baby Shivaay Jagga, Fortis Memorial Research Institute UHID No.13933353, 1 year is a known case of Thalassemia major. He has a Potential Matched Unrelated Donor & requires stem cell Transplant as Curative Therapy. The Estimated cost of the Transplant is Approximately Rs.32,00,000/-.

Please send donation however small by Cheque/D.D/M.O Fav. Save Poor Lives A/c Shivaay Jagga, Our A/c Details: S/B A/c No. 20000913487. S.B.I. R.A.Puram, IFSC CODE:SBIN001855. Please Donate by G-pay No.9884607377, UPI Id: savepoorlives@oksbil. Donations are exempted under 80G of I.T.ACT.

SAVE POOR LIVES, Flat No. A1, Ceebros Garden, Door No.14/76, Kamarajar Salai, Raja Annamalaiapuram, Chennai-600028. Ph. No. 044 42044165 / 9884607377. Email: savepoorlives@gmail.com. Our website: www.savepoorlives.com



Govt. says introduction of MDR will help Indian UPI apps, denies foreign push

Cong. rejects claim that its MPs backed MDR move

Mr. Gogoi reiterated the Congress's demand for withdrawal of the policy, saying it would hurt small merchants, vendors, and entrepreneurs while benefiting U.S. corporations.

EC bars rival factions from using Trinamool name and symbol for Assembly bypolls

Wishes, messages pour in for Modi as the PM celebrates 76th birthday

Congress president and Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha Mallikarjun Kharge and his Lok Sabha counterpart, Rahul Gandhi, greeted Mr. Modi on his 76th birthday.

SC seeks report on 25 unnatural deaths in Manipur camps

INBRIEF



Centre proposes CCTV surveillance at medical stores

The Union Health Ministry has proposed making CCTV surveillance mandatory at licensed premises selling prescription drugs, as part of proposed amendments to the Drugs Rules, 1945. The draft notification, G.S.R. 791(E), issued on September 8, proposes inserting a new provision in Rule 65 requiring the supply of drugs on the prescription of a registered medical practitioner, other than through wholesale dealing, to take place under a CCTV surveillance system installed and maintained at the licensed premises. The Ministry has invited objections and suggestions from stakeholders for 30 days from the date the Gazette was made available.

SC notice to Centre, State over woman's deportation

The Supreme Court on Thursday issued notice to the Centre and authorities in Maharashtra on a petition filed by a man against the detention and deportation of his mother to Bangladesh. The petition also challenged the legality of the standard operating procedure dated May 2, 2025, titled 'Procedure for Deportation of Illegal Bangladeshi Nationals/Rohingya-regarding', and the Immigration and Foreigners Order, 2025. Appearing before a Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, petitioner Sahin Fakir alleged that his mother, Ms. Sahida, was illegally detained and "pushed out" of India into Bangladesh in July without any verification of her nationality.

CBFC calls for action against screening of Umar Khalid film

The Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC) on Thursday asked IIT-Hyderabad authorities to take action against the proposed screening of *Prisoner No. 626710* is Present on its campus. It is a documentary on activist Umar Khalid, who has been in judicial custody over the past six years in the "larger conspiracy" case linked to the 2020 Delhi riots. "Public screening of a documentary film that has not yet been certified by the CBFC is a violation of the Cinematograph Act unless a specific exemption has been sought under the Act," the CBFC said in a post on X, tagging a screenshot showing that the documentary was to be screened at the institution's campus on Friday.

HC refuses to interfere with order on fund use by CHRI

The Delhi High Court on Thursday declined to interfere with an interim order permitting civil society organisation Commonwealth Human Rights Initiative (CHRI) to withdraw ₹20 lakh from its reserve fund to meet operational expenses, despite the cancellation of its FCRA registration. A Bench of Chief Justice D.K. Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia dismissed the Centre's appeal against the May 19 order of a single judge, observing that cancellation of an organisation's FCRA registration does not mean that it ceases to function. It noted that the effect of cancellation was that the organisation could not receive foreign contributions.

Defer Class 6 language policy roll-out to 2027: SC to Centre

Bench says its suggestion is based on logistics and balance of convenience for both students and families; says govt. could use the time to come up with incentives for children for third language

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday urged the Union government to make the three-language policy mandatory for Class 6 from January 1, 2027, rather than "springing a surprise" on the current batch when there is hardly four months left for the year to end.

A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant was reacting to the Centre's reluctance to change its position to start the policy with the current batch of Class 6.

Justice Joymalya Bagchi, on the Bench with Justice V. Mohana, said the court's suggestion to delay the policy implementation in Class 6 was made on the basis of logistics and balance of convenience for both students and families.

Additional Solicitor-General Aishwarya Bhati, appearing for the Centre, agreed to take the court's suggestion to the government for reconsideration of its position on the issue.

"We are not standing in the way. We are only saying that instead of springing a



Under the CBSE guidelines, Classes 7 to 9 were exempted, while the present Class 6 batch was to face full implementation. FILE PHOTO



We are only saying that instead of springing a surprise on this batch, start from 1st of January

surprise on this batch of students, start from the first of January... We are not on a point of law, but on a point of comfort. You can start with children who come into January 1, 2027. It is only four months more," Justice Bagchi reasoned.

Chief Justice Kant said the government could use the time to come up with incentives for the children

to embrace the study of a third language in school.

"The only incentive for them would be to go and play rather than learn a language," Justice Bagchi said lightly.

The judge said the policy was envisaged in 2020. "Push it to 2027 so that everyone comes to terms with the scheme," Justice Bagchi said.

Taking up on the CJ's suggestion, Justice Mohana said the new language could be taught in a lively and engaging manner that would naturally pique the interest of the children. Language, Justice Mohana indicated, should be learnt in an organic manner.

PAC pulls up Railways over gaps in amenities despite promises

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Public Accounts Committee (PAC) on Thursday expressed concern over persistent deficiencies in passenger amenities and sanitation across railway stations, with a recent Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) audit finding that bio-toilets, projected as a game changer by the Indian Railways, were found deficient or non-functional at 491 of the 512 stations inspected.

The findings were discussed at a PAC meeting, headed by senior Congress leader K.C. Venugopal, which examined the CAG's Report No. 31 of 2026 on passenger amenities and sanitation at stations.

Sources said Mr. Venugopal acknowledged the scale and complexity of managing the Indian Railways, but said that should not hamper basic services for citizens. He noted that



K.C. Venugopal

four PAC reports on the subject have been presented since 2007, highlighting key deficiencies, but the Railways ignored the findings. He added that Ministry of Railways continued to submit action-taken reports, without making any significant improvements on the ground.

Sources said the PAC Chairperson directed the Ministry to review the committee's observations, made since its 2007 report, and submit a response within a month detailing measures to address the deficiencies.

"The meeting was one of the most important subjects concerning common passengers in this country. Basic amenities provided to passengers have serious discrepancies, including drinking water, seating arrangements, fans, and roofing on platforms... The audit has pointed out serious lapses on the part of the Railways, which we are examining... After one month, we will call another meeting with Railway officials and we will discuss this" Mr. Venugopal said after the meeting.

The latest audit noted that while the Ministry had informed the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Railways in 2020-21 that it had introduced bio-toilets, water-vending machines and Wi-Fi facilities, several shortcomings remained. Audit teams found deficiencies in water-vending machines at 29 of 77 stations, and Wi-Fi facilities at 65 of 380 stations.

NEET-SS qualifying percentile will be reduced to 30: govt.

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Centre on Thursday agreed to reduce the qualifying percentile for National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test-Super Speciality (NEET-SS) seats from the existing 50 percentile to 30 percentile, even as it agreed to return 40 vacant in-service seats pertaining to Tamil Nadu to the State.

"The matter has since been reconsidered in consultation with the concerned stakeholders. In order to ensure that the available super speciality seats do not remain vacant and that the available training capacity is optimally utilised, it has been decided that the qualifying percentile for NEET-SS may be reduced from the existing 50th percentile to 30th percentile for the purpose of the proposed Special Stray Vacancy Round," a Union government note filed before a Bench headed by Justice P.S. Narasimha said.

Consequently, candidates securing the 30th percentile and above in NEET-SS would become eligible to participate in the special stray vacancy round for NEET-SS seats.

The State was represented by senior advocate A.M. Singhvi, Tamil Nadu Additional Advocate-General Prashanto Chandra Sen and advocate Rupali Samuel. The petitioner, Tamil Nadu Medical Officers Association, was represented by senior advocate P. Wilson, who sought a zero cut-off percentile reduction, as done in the past two years.

The Centre's note said 1,857 super speciality seats were presently lying vacant pursuant to the completion of second round of NEET-SS counselling.

Further, the Centre said its decision to revert the 40 vacant in-service seats to Tamil Nadu was taken in compliance with Supreme Court orders.

"The 40 vacant in-service seats pertaining to Tamil Nadu would be reverted to the State government for the limited purpose of enabling the State to conduct and complete its own stray vacancy round for a period of one week," the Centre submitted.

The court also gave Tamil Nadu leeway to allow NEET-SS candidates upgradation during the one-week special stray vacancy round.

Stem cell therapy for autism only in approved clinical trials: Centre

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

The Union Health Ministry has asked States and Union Territories to ensure that stem cell therapy is offered as standard clinical care only for disease conditions and indications approved by the Ministry, with its use for Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD) restricted to duly approved clinical trials.

In an advisory issued on September 16, the Ministry reiterated the existing regulatory framework governing stem cell research and therapy. The advisory was issued to States and Union Territories that have adopted the Clinical Establishments (Registration and Regulation) Act, 2010, following a January 30, 2026, judgment of the Supreme Court in *Yash Charitable Trust & Ors. v. Union of India & Ors.*

For ASD, the Ministry said therapeutic use of any



ICMR review said that available evidence does not support stem cell therapy for ASD.

type of stem cell must remain confined to duly approved clinical trials in accordance with the National Guidelines for Stem Cell Research, 2017, issued by the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) and the Department of Biotechnology.

Stem cell interventions that have not been approved for routine clinical use, including those offered for autism, and

should not be provided as routine, standard or commercial clinical services, the advisory said.

No supporting evidence

The move comes against the backdrop of the continuing use of stem-cell interventions for autism despite the lack of established evidence supporting them as a standard treatment. An ICMR review has said that available evidence does not support stem cell therapy over behavioural and supportive therapies for ASD and recommended that such therapy be restricted to approved clinical trials.

The Ministry has asked States and Union Territories to disseminate the Supreme Court's directions to State and district regulatory authorities as well as government and private clinical establishments involved in stem cell research, treatment, promotion or administration.

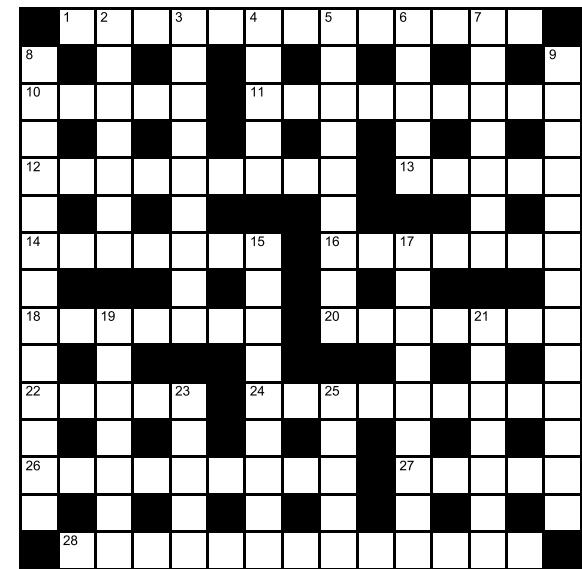
THE HINDU

CROSSWORD+ 14901

(set by Arden)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY



- Across**
- 1 Fancy cloth as a focus to show a bit of sophistication (1,5,2,5)
- 10 Big land owner is fat, clutching his heart (5)
- 11 Dead simple to pack an Indian carpet (9)
- 12 Agree, no one returned the instrument (9)
- 13 The dictator's internal rule (5)

- 14 Always there is a tiny mistake by the setter (7)
- 16 I've a new design to entwine (7)
- 18 Two drinks socially acceptable at the mansion (7)
- 20 The language of money in South America (7)
- 22 Music starts after main band arrives (5)
- 24 After change of hands, augmentation becomes bleak (9)
- 26 Keen to expose plan for ancient building (9)
- 27 Suffer from strike — part of Mumbai spared (5)
- 28 Coal shortage — I go all over the place for an excavator (13)
- Down**
- 2 It's almost two — impatient and worried (7)
- 3 Sabotage — result of a French and the German bomb (9)
- 4 Agatha Christie novel avoiding gate crash in the country (5)
- 5 Cast over relative showing off (9)
- 6 Interest seen among legends for a river (5)
- 7 Am I part of retrenched workers? Showing staying power (7)
- 8 Permits for beer — the entire lot has to go (9,4)
- 9 Shoot and catch on (3,3,7)
- 15 Clarify on cryptic clue, I see (9)
- 17 Evading glide overboard (9)
- 19 Perhaps normal to accept one finally as a benefactor (7)
- 21 Brief copies — recoup odd bits inside (7)
- 23 Followers of Amman hungry, not fed (5)
- 25 Stagger carrying cold fish basket (5)

SUDOKU



Solution to previous puzzle

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

FAITH

Kallazhagar and Ramanuja

Lord Kallazhagar and Acharya Ramanuja cannot be compared by asking who is greater, because both are closely aligned in role and purpose. Tirukudanthai Dr. Venkatesh highlighted similarities between Kallazhagar and Ramanuja in a discourse. First, the beauty and charm (divine beauty): Kallazhagar is known as Azhagar because of his charming divine appearance. Ramanuja is known for his immense spiritual charm and appealing grace, which attract devotees' hearts.

Second, Ilaya Azhwar (young saint/brother) and Kallazhagar are associated with the qualities of Lakshmana (Lord Rama's younger brother), expressing divine humility and closeness. Ramanuja, born as Ilaya Azhwar, is considered an incarnation of Lakshmana. Both Kallazhagar and Ramanuja are connected to Srivilliputhur and Andal. Andal honoured Kallazhagar in Her divine hymns Nachiyar Tirumozhi and Tiruppavai. Ramanuja fulfilled Andal's vow to offer a hundred pots of *Akkaravadisal* (sweet rice pudding) to Kallazhagar, earning him the title Koil Annan, Andal's elder brother.

Kallazhagar and Ramanuja both show mercy and accessibility to common people. Kallazhagar reaches out to ordinary devotees and steps out of his grand temple during the Chithirai festival. Ramanuja shared the sacred mantra (Tirumantra) openly from the temple tower of Tirukoshtiyur to ensure salvation for all people.

Kallazhagar is the ultimate grantor of liberation (moksha) through His direct divine grace. Ramanuja serves as the ultimate Acharya (guru), who holds the Lord's feet and guides devotees safely to moksha.

INBRIEF



TVS expects single-digit growth for 2-wheeler industry

TVS Motor Company, which on Thursday rolled out festive enhancements across its premium motorcycle portfolio of Apache and Ronin, said it remains “cautiously optimistic” about demand in the upcoming festive season. The company expects the two-wheeler industry to post single-digit growth this festive season on account of a high base created by pre-buying ahead of last year’s GST rate cut, even as it highlighted strong momentum in the premium motorcycle segment. “We are looking at a single-digit festive growth [for the industry] because last year, due to GST, there was already a huge impact as people were holding back purchases for a long time before the festive season started,” TVS Motor Company Head Business, Premium, Vimal Sumbly told PTI. Building on this momentum ahead of the festive season, TVS on Thursday unveiled 18 new motorcycles with enhancements across its premium range, including the Apache RTR 160, Apache RTR 160 4V, Apache RTR 200 4V and RR 310, along with the Ronin.

Govt. puts 25 coal blocks on sale in 16th round of auctions

The Coal Ministry Thursday formally inaugurated that sixteenth round of commercial mine auctions putting forth 25 blocks, comprising 21 fully explored and four partially explored mines. The mines are spread across nine-coal bearing states including Arunachal Pradesh, Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Odisha, Telangana and West Bengal. The latest round forms part of the government’s larger commercial coal mining framework that has had 147 mines auctioned till date, which are expected to cumulatively bring forth revenues of over ₹47,500 crore and entails projected capital investment of more than ₹55,000 crore across nine coal-bearing states.

51% of India’s July oil imports from Russia

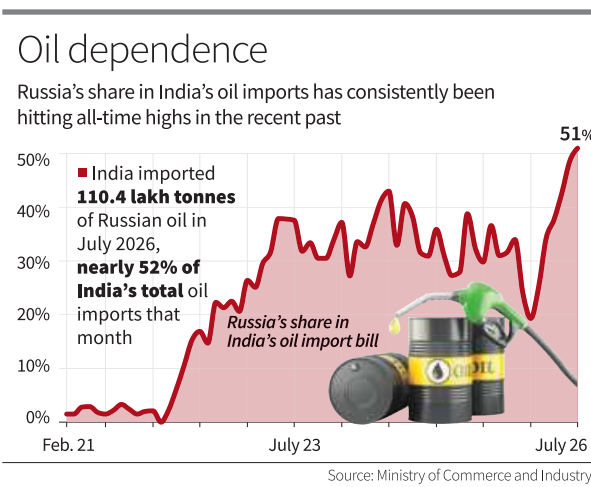
Bill passed by U.S. House of Representatives seeks to impose tariffs of up to 100% on top 5 countries absorbing the largest shares of Russia’s oil

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Russia accounted for more than 51% of India’s oil imports in July, an all-time-high, up from just a little less than 50% in the previous month, the latest official data shows. This comes even as the U.S. House of Representatives on Wednesday passed a Bill that could see 100% tariffs being imposed on India and a few other countries for their import of Russian oil.

The U.S. House of Representatives passed the ‘Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026’ on September 16. The Act seeks to impose tariffs of up to 100% on the top 5 countries absorbing the largest shares of Russia’s oil exports.

An analysis of data from the Ministry of Commerce and Industry shows that India imported 110.4 lakh tonnes of oil from Russia in July 2026, the latest month for which data is available. This works out to nearly 52% of India’s total oil im-



ports that month, the highest-ever share that Russian oil has enjoyed.

India’s oil imports from Russia in July 2026 were also 26% higher than in June, and nearly 55% higher than in July last year.

This sharp increase in volumes, coupled with elevated oil prices, also meant that India’s Russian oil import bill shot up in July 2026 as compared to last year. That is, India’s import bill on Russian oil stood at \$7.3 billion in July 2026 more than double the \$3.6 billion spent in July last year. The U.S. legislation

that threatens the tariffs for such imports will now head to the desk of U.S. President Donald Trump. It is expected to become law soon after, since Mr. Trump has been keen to strangle Russia’s oil exports in a bid to cut off financing for the country’s war with Ukraine.

The data, however, shows that India received Russian oil at a slight discount. While India paid an average of \$669 a tonne for its total oil imports in July 2026, it paid Russia an average of \$658.6 a tonne for its oil that month.

Semicon 2.0 locks in chip assets sale

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Approved chip plants under the Semicon 2.0 programme will not be allowed to sell or mortgage

any part of the project till the declaration of commercial production of the entire project, as per guidelines issued on Thursday.

Units receiving fiscal support under the scheme

shall have to remain in commercial production for a period of at least (three) years from the date of commencement of commercial production and provide an undertaking to the same.

‘Oil India to spend ₹15,000 crore on deepwater exploration over 3 years’

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

Oil India Ltd. (OIL) has outlined ₹15,000 crore capital expenditure for exploration in deepwater and ultra deepwater areas over the next three years, Ranjit Rath, CMD, told reporters.

“In terms of preparedness, we have already created a capex of ₹15,000 crore [for deepwater and ultra deepwater exploration],” stated Mr. Rath.

Numaligarh refinery

The OIL chief also said he expected the 9 million tonne per annum (MTPA) expansion work at Numaligarh refinery to be com-



Ranjit Rath

pleted by the end of FY27 with stabilisation likely taking 9-12 months more.

On overseas activities, Mr. Rath said OIL would focus on exploration and producing assets though primary interest tilted towards the latter.

The capital expenditure will further boost the Maharatna explorer-producer’s offshore exploration footprint across the Andaman, Kerala-Konkan, Krishna-Godavari and Mahanadi basins.

Oil India had already undertaken seismic studies, and the interpretation of the findings would help identify potential drilling locations, said the company’s chief.

Responding to a query from *The Hindu*, Mr. Rath said the company does not anticipate any major challenges in accessing the infrastructure or technology required for offshore exploration and production.

Mr. Rath informed that the state-owned explorer-producer had relinquished assets in Bangladesh and Gabon as part of broader consolidation strategy.

Prospective areas

Speaking to *The Hindu*, he explained, “As part of our overseas assets, we will continue to look at more prospective areas - both producing and exploration assets but the primary interest will be in producing assets which will give us an early or an immediate monetisation opportunity.”

The CMD added exploration would continue to be OIL’s mainstay on the domestic front.

India’s August crude imports dropped 3%, spend rose 18%: data

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

India’s imports of crude oil in August slid 3% though the import bill stood about 18.2% higher over same month last year, as per provisional government data, indicating prolonged West Asia tension uncertainty.

August also saw import volumes of and spending on liquefied natural gas (LNG) staying almost unchanged year-on-year. India’s crude oil basket averaged \$90.19/barrel in August versus \$82.04/barrel in July and \$69.11/barrel in August last year.

India’s net import bill – the difference between imports of petroleum pro-

ducts, crude and gas imports and exports of petroleum products – was flat at \$9.3 billion.

India’s refiners imported 19 million metric tonne (MMT) of crude in August for almost \$11.7 billion against \$9.9 billion to import 19.6 MMT of crude oil same month last year.

The unchanged net import bill can be attributed to India’s refiners earning about 43% more money from exports despite a more than 14% decline in quantities supplied during the reported period.

August LNG imports grew 0.1% to 2.915 million standard cubic meter for which India spent some \$1.2 billion.

PSU general insurers log ₹10,051-crore loss, pvt. insurers in green

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI

The four public sector general insurers swung to a combined net loss of ₹10,050.79 crore in 2025-26 from a net profit of ₹802.87 crore in the previous year, reversing the improvement seen over the preceding two years, as per latest data from General Insurance Council.

The deterioration was accompanied by a sharp widening of underwriting losses. Combined, the four insurers’ underwriting loss rose to ₹30,892.09 crore in FY26 from ₹18,366.41 crore in FY25. The combined ratio increased to 134.37% from 121.23%.

A combined ratio above

100% means claims and operating expenses exceed premium.

Solvency ratio measures an insurer’s capital cushion against its regulatory capital requirement, while the combined ratio measures underwriting performance by comparing claims and operating expenses with premiums.

The PSU insurers reported a combined net loss of ₹6,740.01 crore in FY22 and ₹10,592.64 crore in FY23 before logging a profit of ₹100.37 crore in FY24 and ₹802.87 crore in FY25.

Private general insurers however, were profitable in FY26. They clocked combined underwriting loss of ₹13,657.92 crore and ₹8,580.29 crore net profit.

कार्यालय अतिरिक्त मुख्य अभियन्ता, सा.नि.वि., संभाग द्वितीय उदयपुर नु. बौसवाड़ा
क्रमांक : सी-462
दिनांक : 11.09.2026
अल्पकालिन निविदा सूचना संख्या - 09 / 2026-27
NIB Code :- PWD2627A2683
सड़क निर्माण कार्य हेतु इच्छुक संवेदकों से ऑनलाईन माध्यम से दिनांक 12.09.2026 से दिनांक 22.09.2026, सायं 06:00 बजे तक निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा का अन्य विवरण वेबसाइट (http://www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in) और http://www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in) पर देखा जा सकता है। उपापन की कुल अनुमानित लागत राशि रु. Rs. 1087.01 लाख है।
UBN- PWD2627WLOB11908
DIPR/C/15983/2026

THE KERALA STATE BEVERAGES (MANUFACTURING & MARKETING) CORPORATION LTD
(A GOVERNMENT OF KERALA UNDERTAKING)
BEVCO TOWER, PALAYAM, VIKAS BHAVAN P.O., TRIVANDRUM-695 033, Phone: 0471 2791001
E-TENDER ADVERTISEMENT
Ref: No.: KSBC/4142/2024-SEC5 18.09.2026
E-tenders in a two-cover system are invited on behalf of the Kerala State Beverages Corporation (KSBC) from eligible, experienced bidders for the following work: For more details visit www.etenders.kerala.gov.in
e-Tender ID Location Bid submission End date
2026_KSBC_869564_1 Supply of eco-friendly Cloth Carry Bags to FL-09 Warehouses of BEVCO across Kerala 29-Sep-2026 05:00 PM
Sd/-
Chairperson & Managing Director

AHMEDABAD MUNICIPAL CORPORATION
LIGHT DEPARTMENT - TENDER NOTICE
AMC invites sealed competitive bids from interested Bidders for the below mentioned work:
1 IMPLEMENTATION OF 75 MW (AC) GRID-CONNECTED GROUND-MOUNTED SOLAR PV POWER PROJECT ALONG WITH 7.5 MW / 30 MWh BATTERY ENERGY STORAGE SYSTEM (BESS) UNDER GROUP CAPTIVE MODE FOR AHMEDABAD MUNICIPAL CORPORATION (AMC) IN THE STATE OF GUJARAT.
Online Submission up to Date : 09/10/2026 Only up to 04:00 PM.
Last Date of Submission of (Hardcopy) Date : 14/10/2026 up to 04:00 PM.
Tender details available on <https://tender.nprocure.com>

BANGALORE ELECTRICITY SUPPLY COMPANY LIMITED
(Wholly Owned Government of Karnataka Undertaking)
BRIEF TENDER NOTIFICATION
(Through KPP Portal Only)
BESCOM invites tenders vide inquiry No: **BESCOM/2026-27/SE0498** through KPP Portal from eligible bidders for “Implementation of Common Billing Solution across all ESCOMs of Karnataka”. Bid documents Available from: **21.09.2026, 04:00 PM Onwards.**
The Tenders can be obtained through KPP portal website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> Aspiring Bidders need to register on KPP portal. Further Bidders can take assistance with KPPP help desk contact numbers (080-46010000, 080-68948777) or email at support@eprocelpdesk.com.
Sd/-
General Manager (ICT & MIS.), BESCOM, 5th Floor, Belaku Bhavana, K.R. Circle, Bengaluru-560 001.

Dr. NTR UNIVERSITY OF HEALTH SCIENCES :: A.P :: VIJAYAWADA-3
No. 23/WeTS/AE/26
TENDER NOTICE
Sealed Tenders are invited for the following work at Dr. NTR University of Health Sciences, Vijayawada.
SI No. Name of the work
1. Peripheral Scanning and onscreen evaluation of Answer Booklets i.e., Computer Based Evaluation and up-loading the data for Dr. NTR UHS, Vijayawada
Note: For further details visit www.approcurement.gov.in
Sd/- Dr. T. Sai Sudheer, REGISTRAR

Kerala State IT Mission
Department of Electronics & IT,
Government of Kerala.
Website: <http://www.itmission.kerala.gov.in/>
TENDER NOTICE
1. Tender for the Supply, Installation and Commissioning of Storage Solution at Kerala State Data Centres.
Tender ID : 2026_KSITM_869351_1
Tender Reference No. DDFS/nSDC/648/2014-KSITM
2. Tender for the Supply, Installation and Commissioning of servers at Kerala State Data Centres.
Tender ID : 2026_KSITM_869968_1
Tender Reference No. SDC/19/2016-KSITM
Detailed Notification and RFP documents can be downloaded from <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in/>
D3/542/2026/I&PRD

CENTRAL ELECTRICITY REGULATORY COMMISSION
6th, 7th, & 8th Floor, Tower-B, World Trade Centre, Nauroji Nagar, New Delhi-110029
Petition No. 129/TD/2026 Dated: 14.9.2026
NOTICE UNDER CLAUSE (a) OF SUB-SECTION (5) OF SECTION 15 OF THE ELECTRICITY ACT, 2003 (the Act)
An application for the grant of a Category-V licence for inter-State trading in electricity in all States and Union Territories of India has been made before the Commission by **SKay Infratech Private Limited**, F-437, 4th Floor Artha Mart Techzone-IV, Noida Ext., Gautam Budha Nagar-201306, U.P.
2. A copy of the application, along with its annexures and enclosures, made by the applicant for the grant of an inter-State trading licence to **SKay Infratech Private Limited** before the Commission can be accessed at the website www.neplindia.co.in or inspected by any person in the Commission's office by following the laid down procedure.
3. On consideration of the material available on record, the Commission is satisfied that prima facie the applicant qualifies for the grant of a licence for inter-State trading in electricity and by order dated 14.9.2026, the Commission has proposed to grant a Category-V licence to the applicant for inter-State trading in electricity in all States and Union Territories of India.
4. Notice is hereby given in pursuance of clause (a) of sub-section (5) of Section 15 of the Act to invite suggestions or objections, if any, to the proposal to grant the licence for inter-State trading in electricity as aforesaid by the Commission to be received by the undersigned latest by **3.10.2026** at the above noted address. The objections or suggestions received after the specified date shall not be considered.
5. The Commission has fixed the application for final disposal on **6.10.2026** and the person who files the suggestions or objections may in his discretion attend the hearing, for which no TA/DA shall be paid by the Commission.
Sd/-
(Harpreet Singh Pruthi)
Secretary

Saudi strikes in Yemen killed one person and targeted three telecom towers on Thursday, Houthi media said, in the latest attacks since the group seized control of the Red Sea coast. Meanwhile, military sources said fighting between the Houthis and Yemeni government forces and their Saudi backers has killed 63 people in 24 hours, AFP

Israel has added a tender for 2,167 housing units to E1 settlement expansion plan, Israeli rights groups said of a project that critics say endangers a future Palestinian state. The project would bisect the occupied West Bank and cut it off from East Jerusalem, fragmenting the land Palestinians hope will form the heart of a state. REUTERS

The Palestinian Authority slammed a decision by the U.S. to refuse visas for its officials to attend the UN General Assembly in New York next week, a move which includes President Mahmoud Abbas. The Trump administration took the same step last year, forcing the Palestinian leader to address the body by video. AFP

Pakistan and China have operationalised a joint mechanism for managing their common border, a move rejected by India, which said that the body has no legal basis to decide on arrangements related to Indian territory under illegal occupation. The inaugural meeting of the Commission was held in Islamabad. PTI

BLITZKRIEG

Abhishek smashes fastest ton in a T20I featuring Test-playing nations



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Abhishek Sharma scored the fastest hundred in a T20I featuring Test-playing nations. His 30-ball century against Afghanistan in New Delhi on Thursday bettered Kiwi Finn Allen's effort (33b) versus South Africa earlier this year. Estonia's Sahil Chauhan (27b) holds the record for the fastest T20I ton. It was against Cyprus in 2024.

MAKING MERRY

Abhishek breaks record for highest percentage of runs in boundaries



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Abhishek Sharma broke the record for the highest percentage of runs scored in boundaries in a T20I hundred. The India opener scored 94.44% of his runs in fours and sixes (102/108) against the Afghans. It bettered Turkiye's Muhammad Fahad's 93.33% (112/120) against Bulgaria in Sofia last year.

DOMINANT SHOW

Vlaeminck and Mills claim three each as Australia-A blanks India-A



FILE PHOTO

Tayla Vlaeminck, *in pic.*, and Lilly Mills scalped three apiece as Australia-A beat India-A by seven runs at New Chandigarh on Thursday to sweep the three-match T20 series. **The scores:** Australia-A 168/5 in 20 overs (Webb 52, Learoyn 61) bt India-A 161 in 19.5 overs (Vrinda 69, Tejal 42, Vlaeminck 3/24, Mills 3/40).

CLOSE CALL

Pakistan survives Thailand scare to reach Asian Games semifinals



PCB

Pakistan survived a scare against Thailand to seal a semifinal spot in the Asian Games women's cricket competition while Bangladesh advanced on the basis of its higher ranking after its match against China was abandoned due to a wet outfield. **The scores:** Thailand 91/4 in 11 overs lost to Pakistan 92/7 in 10.4 overs. **Toss:** Pakistan.

Abhishek's hurricane hundred powers Men in Blue's emphatic series sweep

The left-hander's record-breaking 34-ball 108 and fellow-opener Samson's fifty take India to 221 for seven; the Afghans get bundled out for 94

CRICKET

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

Six-hitting is a skill that Abhishek Sharma has honed to perfection. He can make it appear ridiculously easy, as though he is playing around with a joystick in a video game, but make no mistake: few can do what the 26-year-old does time and again in the T20 version. A sublime example came in the third T20I against Afghanistan at the Arun Jaitley Stadium on Thursday as Abhishek hammered a record-breaking 34-ball 108, studded with nine fours and 11 sixes, to take India to 221 for seven.

With Afghanistan capitulating for 94 in response, Shreyas Iyer & Co. completed a resounding 127-run win for a 3-0 sweep. Nitish Kumar struck thrice in an over while Ravi Bishnoi also provided three breakthroughs.

Abhishek's century took merely 30 balls, the fastest against a Test-playing nation and the third-quickest in all in this format. Sanju Samson chipped in with 50 off 35 balls, forging a sensational opening stand of 142 in 9.5 overs. The surface appeared to be a shirtfront when Abhishek and Samson were on song, but the others didn't find it as easy.



Breathtaking: Abhishek hit nine fours and 11 maxims in his dazzling knock. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Abhishek imposed himself straightaway. In the second over, Azmatullah Omarzai felt the pinch. The first of the opener's maxims came when he swi-

velled and pulled effortlessly beyond deep square-leg. Omarzai persisted with the shorter length and paid the price. Off the fourth ball, he

pulled out a forehand slap past mid-on for four. Two deliveries later, he made room and slashed a back-of-a-length delivery over cover for another six.

SCOREBOARD

INDIA

Sanju Samson c Rashid b Omarzai 50 (35b, 2x4, 4x6), Abhishek Sharma c Gurbaz b Rashid 108 (34b, 9x4, 11x6), Tilak Varma run out 2 (5b), Shreyas Iyer run out 29 (20b, 2x6), Shivam Dube c Rashid b Omarzai 14 (10b, 1x4, 1x6), Ishan Kishan run out 10 (8b, 1x4), Nitish Kumar c Mujeeb b Ahmadzai 1 (4b), Axar Patel (not out) 5 (4b), Ravi Bishnoi (not out) 0 (0b); Extras (w-2): 2; Total (for seven wkts. in 20 overs): 221.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-142 (Abhishek, 9.5 overs), 2-152 (Tilak, 11.1), 3-164 (Samson, 13.1), 4-186 (Dube, 15.3), 5-205 (Kishan, 17.5), 6-206 (Nitish, 18.3), 7-218 (Shreyas, 19.4).

AFGHANISTAN BOWLING

Farooqi 4-0-39-0, Omarzai 3-0-27-2, Mujeeb 4-0-45-0, Nabi 1-0-29-0, Rashid 4-0-43-1, Ahmadzai 4-0-38-1.

AFGHANISTAN

Rahmanullah Gurbaz b Axar 15 (11b, 3x4), Ibrahim Zadran c Kishan b Yash Thakur 25 (16b,

4x4, 1x6), Sediqullah Atal c Abhishek b Axar 1 (3b), Darwish Rasooli b Bumrah 0 (1b), Azmatullah Omarzai c Bishnoi b Nitish 17 (13b, 1x4, 1x6), Noor ul Rahman c Nitish b Bishnoi 11 (15b, 2x4), Mohammad Nabi b Nitish 8 (9b, 1x4), Rashid Khan b Bishnoi 6 (5b, 1x4), Mujeeb ur Rahman b Nitish 0 (2b), Abdollah Ahmadzai c Axar b Bishnoi 6 (8b, 1x4), Fazalhaq Farooqi (not out) 0 (2b); Extras (lb-1, w-4): 5; Total (in 14.1 overs): 94.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-31 (Gurbaz, 3.1), 2-33 (Sediqullah, 3.6), 3-39 (Rasooli, 4.5), 4-47 (Ibrahim, 5.2), 5-70 (Noor, 8.5), 6-81 (Nabi, 11.1), 7-82 (Omarzai, 11.3), 8-82 (Mujeeb, 11.5), 9-89 (Rashid, 12.5).

INDIA BOWLING

Nitish 4-0-25-3, Bumrah 2-0-16-1, Yash Thakur 2-0-17-1, Axar 3-0-9-2, Bishnoi 3.1-0-26-3.

Toss: Afghanistan.
PoM and PoS: Abhishek. India won by 127 runs to clinch series 3-0.

Having quickly sized up the Afghan attack, the southpaw's carnage found a higher gear. The next over, bowled by Fazalhaq Farooqi, went for 23 runs as the Punjab lad stitched together a sequence that read 6, 6, 4, 4.

Afghanistan turned to spin early in the hope of disturbing India's rhythm. Instead, Samson, who had scored three off his first seven balls, joined the six-hitting party. In the fourth over, he deposited Mujeeb ur Rahman over long-on.

What followed was a 29-

run over by off-spinner Mohammad Nabi as the openers took turns to flex their firepower. By the time leggie Rashid Khan conceded 15 runs in the final over of the PowerPlay, India had raced to 100 for none.

In the ninth over, Abhishek entered the record books by reaching the three-figure mark. Ironically, his celebration was unlike the action that had transpired till then: he took off his helmet, sat down and soaked in the moment with a meditative pose.



Contrasting fortunes: Gukesh was held while Nihal won. FIDE

Nihal saves the day for India; women cruise

CHESS OLYMPIAD

Sports Bureau

Nihal Sarin saved the blushes for India on day two of the Chess Olympiad at Samarkand. His win on the second board was the reason why India, the defending champion, could beat a much lower-rated Indonesia 2.5-1.5 in the Open section on Thursday. Nihal, though, was in considerable trouble in his game against Arif Abdul Hafiz before he won in 37 moves. R. Praggnanandhaa, the in-form player who was making his first appearance in this edition, World champion D. Gukesh and Vidit Gujrathi were all held to draws.

Praggnanandhaa did try his best to stretch his opponent Susanto Megaranto, who, however, played solidly to ensure that the rook-pawn endgame was indeed drawn, after 79 moves.

The Indian women, also the reigning champions, were more convincing than the men, just as they were in the opening round.

They beat Finland 3.5-0.5.

There were wins for Divya Deshmukh, Vantika Agrawal and B. Savitha Shri, but on the top board, R. Vaishali had to settle for a draw with Anastasia Keinanen in 88 moves. So the top-seeded Indian women could not quite score the full points, which they had against Dominican Republic.

The results (second round):

Open: India bt Indonesia 2.5-1.5 (R. Praggnanandhaa drew with Susanto Megaranto; Nihal Sarin bt Arif Abdul Hafiz; D. Gukesh drew with Satriya Cahaya; Vidit Gujrathi drew with Nayaka Budhidharma) Uzbekistan bt Peru 3.5-0.5; USA bt Mongolia 2.5-1.5; China bt Chile 3-1; Germany bt Uzbekistan-3 3.5-0.5; Azerbaijan bt The Philippines 3-1. **Women:** India bt Finland 3.5-0.5 (R. Vaishali drew with Anastasia Keinanen; Divya Deshmukh bt Johanna Paasikangas; Vantika Agrawal bt Sara-Olivia Sippola; B. Savitha Shri bt Heja Lehtinen). Uzbekistan bt Ecuador 4-0; Kazakhstan bt Bosnia & Herzegovina 3-1; USA bt Belgium 4-0; Georgia drew with Montenegro 2-2; Ukraine bt Lithuania 4-0; Netherlands bt Luxembourg 4-0; China bt Colombia 3.5-0.5; Azerbaijan bt Denmark 4-0.

For Japan's cricket team, the occasion means more

ASIAN GAMES

Jonathan Selvaraj
NAGOYA

India's women's cricket team, ranked No. 3 in T20Is, opens its Asian Games campaign against 39th-ranked Japan on Friday at Korogi Sports Park in Nissihin, Aichi.

On paper it looks lopsided: India fields full-time professionals, while Japan's squad juggles jobs and studies around international cricket. Japan hadn't even qualified for the 2022 Hangzhou Games.

For captain Mai Yanagida, the occasion means more than the opponent. "It is incredibly exciting. I have waited a decade to play in the Asian Games," she tells *Sportstar*.

Japan's men debuted in Hangzhou, beating Cambodia and briefly making national news. "The Asian Games is like the Olympics. It's one of those things that people really do kind of get



All in: The Japanese team at a practice session recently. JCA

behind," says Alan Curr, COO of Japan Cricket Association.

The women now get a chance to showcase the sport at home. "I hope this will be an opportunity to raise awareness of cricket and inspire people to dream of aiming for the Japanese national team in the future," says 39-year-old pacer Kurumi Ota.

Only 14 women's cricket clubs exist nationwide and Ota, a systems engineer, stepped away from cricket for seven years, returning only after a major project launched.

Still, she carries something rare: an Asian Games medal, bronze from

Guangzhou in 2010, cricket's Games debut. "Winning the bronze medal together with my teammates is my fondest memory," she says.

The change since is striking – from practising under overpasses to today's international-standard grounds. Both players are eager to face India's stars, Yanagida watching Shafali Verma and Smriti Mandhana, Ota targeting Harmanpreet Kaur.

"A lot of Japanese people still do not know their country has a cricket team," Yanagida says. "Although awareness is growing, most people are still genuinely surprised".

Chaos and crisis: Japan in an alternate universe?

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

For years, Japan was the epitome of perfection, the country that planned things down to the last possible detail. The Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games, starting on Saturday, threatens to dent that reputation.

It began with concerns, whispered initially before growing loud enough and from quarters widespread enough, about the city and the organisers' preparedness for an event whose magnitude is larger than the Olympics. It became immediate when delegates from various National Olympic associations expressed reservations in private about the conditions and facilities for athletes and officials.

None of it caused alarm, given Japan's reputation of pulling off mega events without a glitch. The Tokyo Olympics, in the immediate aftermath of Covid, had received appreciation for managing a never-before situation. The 2026 Asiad, however, has been far from it.

The first lot of Indian



Not the ideal start: The organisers have come under the scanner for accommodation issues. AFP

athletes, including rowers who landed in the city, struggled to get accommodation, waiting without any arrangements for almost 12 hours.

The officials fared no better. A quick ask around made it clear that it was becoming the norm, with athletes from several countries suffering similar fate. The accommodation – on cruise ship Costa Serena and modified shipping containers in keeping with the organisers' insistence on sustainability – has also come in for criticism, both

for poor quality and insufficient quantity.

Videos of the containers have been shocking to say the least, resembling detention centres than athlete residences. South Korea's Byun Jun-hyung, member of the basketball team, took to social media to show a leaking sink and wet floor, pleading "Please help me." An image of Indian shot putter Tajinderpal Singh Toor showed him in his allotted container with the space and beds clearly too small for him.

There have been logisti-

cal issues as well, with Korea and Qatar football teams being bussed to the baseball stadium on Tuesday. The Chinese badminton team had to rely on local Chinese to travel from the airport. Many Indian athletes, who did finally manage to get places to stay, were welcomed with closed shutters and a notice on Thursday morning saying breakfast was not included in their bookings.

"The organisers have washed their hands of everything and said that there is no accommodation and

that we need to manage things ourselves. We have got our rowers and other athletes booked into different hotels. There is hardly any support or facility at the airport.

"I am staying in a small container but imagine the plight of athletes who are taller and muscular. We have been raising the issues every day at the CDM meetings and will do it again tomorrow (Friday)," Indian contingent's Chef de Mission (CDM) Sahdev Yadav said.

"There have been cases where coaches, team officials, and athletes have been assigned the same room. It creates challenging situations such as men and women being assigned together," Japan's deputy Chef de Mission Hisashi Mizutori told a news conference on Thursday.

The positive remains the volunteers but they are few and far between that they are practically non-existent. The city has nothing to indicate an event of this magnitude is happening. Japan might still pull it off. But the claims of perfection have been undone.



GETTY IMAGES

Cold blood, hot streak

An Achilles injury, just four days of practice, and a final against the top seed and two-time defending champion... Rybakina's path to the US Open title was anything but simple. However, her tennis made it look that way. In the process, she ascended to the top of the world rankings

Anirudh Velamuri

Sport has an old rule about momentum: catch fire late in a season, and the off-season usually douses it. That sentiment holds for most part. But, as with most things in life, there are exceptions. Elena Rybakina's is one.

The Russian-born Kazakh couldn't get past the fourth round at the Grand Slams last year. Form looked to have deserted her and the season was all set to be chalked up as yet another 'learning experience' in her career.

Then, it all changed.

She came through a tough set of tournaments in September and October, won in Ningbo and closed the year by defeating Aryna Sabalenka in the WTA Finals title decider, taking home more than \$five million in prize money, the largest purse in women's tennis history at that time.

The soft-spoken 27-year-old later disappeared for the off-season. When she resumed action, she picked up from where she had left off, looking just as dangerous as she'd been. Rybakina reached the Australian Open final without dropping a set, clawed back from 0-3 down in the third set to beat Sabalenka again for her second Major. She became

the first player in eight years to win the WTA Finals and the Australian Open in succession.

What followed was, by any measure, a strong season: a title in Stuttgart along with runner-up finishes at Indian Wells and the Canadian Open. She also banked her 400th career win on the way.

The underlying numbers are absurd. Since last year's US Open, nobody on the Tour has won more matches than Rybakina (62) and nobody has beaten more

top-10 players (16, with a 16-6 record). She leads the field in winners (1,569), in aces (394) and break points saved (65.5%). She made six finals (tied with Jessica Pegula for most on the Tour) and clinched four crowns, more than anyone else.

Put it all together and you get a first-time World No. 1: the first from Kazakhstan, and at 27 years and 89 days, the second-oldest woman ever to reach the summit for the first time. She rose to the top, tournament by tournament, so relentlessly that by the time it actually happened, nobody blinked.

And yet a year ago, the idea of Rybakina dethroning Sabalenka looked unthinkable, unattainable even. Last September, she had 3,833 points to Sabalenka's 11,225 – barely a third. By last month, that gap had shrunk to 360 points, before she finally ended Sabalenka's 99-week reign as the No. 1.

Even before she ascended to the top of

the rankings, Rybakina had already beaten a reigning World No. 1 nine times, a mark bettered only by Gabriela Sabatini's 10. The Kazakh has now beaten nine of the last 10 women who have held the top ranking. Only Ashleigh Barty got away.

Crowning moment

Impressive as all that is, the true crowning moment of Rybakina's year came at Flushing Meadows; she barely stumbled, let alone look anywhere near beatable. The strange part is that heading into the tournament, nobody was asking how far she'd go. They were instead wondering if she'd play at all.

On August 14, she was steam-rolled by Iga Swiatek to the Canadian Open title. A week later, Rybakina was forced to retire after just five games of her Cincinnati quarterfinal against the same opponent.

An Achilles injury was suspected, though little else was confirmed. In the week before the US Open, Rybakina barely picked up a racquet. As far as preparation for one of the biggest titles in the sport goes, it was far from ideal.

"It wasn't the best time, for sure, because I was so upset. I didn't know how it was going to be, day by day. We arrived in New York, did an MRI and it didn't look that great. We had to talk with a lot of doctors to get an opinion on what we should do," she said, hours after conquering New York.

She started practising just four days before the US Open got underway and with each match, she looked less like a woman shaking off rust and more like one reminding everyone who she was. The power was there and the aces were pulled out of nowhere when they were needed the most.

"Just four days of practice, a lot of belief in myself and talking with the team non-stop about the tactics... that's how I played in Canada, how I played in Cincinnati. I mean, it's just so many things. Everything went my way. I'm shocked."

Her tennis over the fortnight told a different story. Nothing about this triumph was shocking. Everything came together for Rybakina one way or the other.

Sabalenka loves to feast on her opponent's second serves, as Pegula was harshly reminded in the semifinals. So when Rybakina landed just eight of her 30 first serves in the opening set of the final, logic dictated that the Belarusian would seize control of the contest.

The logic was wrong. Rybakina pulled out heavier, quicker second serves and deep, powerful groundstrokes to put Sabalenka on the back foot. If one moment captured how the final unfolded, it was the last game of the opening set, where Rybakina couldn't hit a first serve but ended up on top despite everything thrown at her.

By the end of the night, as she did at

the WTA Finals, Rybakina had a trophy and a fat cheque in hand, but this time as World No. 1. Four years ago, she barely managed a smile after conquering Wimbledon, and the tennis world wondered if she'd ever let herself feel a title the way champions are supposed to. In New York, something shifted. The fists were raised, the celebration stayed brief; however, underneath it, for the first time, was an unmistakable and hard-earned joy.

Rybakina wins the way glaciers move: silently, relentlessly, until you look up one day and the entire landscape has changed. New York didn't just hand her a trophy; it handed women's tennis a warning wrapped in ice – quiet on the outside, catastrophic on the inside.

A year earlier, after finishing runner-up to Rybakina at the WTA Finals, Sabalenka – far from being tennis' most gracious loser – was overheard reaching for a Russian idiom that translated to: "Once a year, even a stick shoots," suggesting Rybakina's form was little more than a fluke. Famous last words.

Overcoming controversy

Like most of the sport's best players, Rybakina hasn't always made headlines for the right reasons. First came the injuries and health scares that dragged her out of tournaments through 2024 and '25. Then her 'worrying' relationship with coach Stefano Vukov landed under the microscope.

In September 2024, she fired Vukov and hired Novak Djokovic's former coach Goran Ivanisevic, before reinstating Vukov. A WTA investigation later found that Vukov had engaged in abusive conduct towards Rybakina, and he was banned from coaching at WTA events in January 2025. The ban was overturned on appeal that August.

Rybakina never softened her stance towards the WTA through it all, even declining to pose for a photo with the then-CEO Portia Archer after beating Sabalenka to win the WTA Finals on November 8.

Long before the WTA formally looked into the Vukov relationship, fans and pundits had already suspected that something was off. He was always very vocal in relentlessly criticising during matches, well beyond any reasonable idea of 'tough love' coaching.

One can argue that Vukov has been noticeably softer since the ban ended. Criticism has largely given way to encouragement. Optimists will call it a man who learnt his lesson. Cynics will call it a man who learnt to behave when the cameras were rolling.

Rybakina herself has stayed quiet on the specifics, but she's hinted that having her team back in place has mattered.

"I think I have a very good team and good people around me now. It definitely helps. A lot was going on in the previous

year outside of the court. I think now all my focus is on tennis. I can't always perform at my best. There are always ups and downs, but I think we've been doing a very good job, taking the right decisions in certain situations, because every day is a challenge," she said last week.

The Vukov chapter may never be fully closed in public, but it changes nothing about where Rybakina stands right now. What once looked like a hot streak has long since stopped resembling one. Nothing about her has come out as a fluke.

She will now head into tournaments, starting with the China Open later this month, as the top seed and a clear title favourite. Given how balanced she is in success and adversity, none of that seems likely to rattle her.

"I feel like you will appreciate and think about it [becoming World No. 1] even more when you finish your career. For now, you need to keep going. You never know how long you're going to stay. All my thoughts are just for the next match," she said after her quarterfinal win over Qinwen Zheng.

Call it humility. Call it how elite athletes are wired. Call it a deliberate way of shrugging off the spotlight before it gets too heavy. Whatever it is, one thing isn't up for debate: the girl who once played tennis as an after-school pastime, who didn't consider it a career until she was 17, has walked out of New York as the most dominant force in women's tennis. Rybakina is pure potential energy, coiled at the very peak of her arc. Buckle up.

THE GIST

Since the 2025 US Open, nobody on the Tour has won more matches than Rybakina (62) and nobody has beaten more top-10 players (16, with a 16-6 record) than her

In the same period, the Kazakh made six finals (tied with Pegula for most on the Tour) and won four titles, more than anyone else

An Achilles issue nearly kept her out of this season's US Open. She recovered in time to go all the way, beating Sabalenka in the final

Last year, Rybakina couldn't go past the fourth round at the Slams. This season, she has won two Majors and also become the new World No. 1

By September 2025, she had 3,833 points to Sabalenka's 11,225 – barely a third. In the space of 12 months, Rybakina has overturned that deficit and ended the latter's 99-week reign at the top of the rankings

The ace is Rybakina's most potent weapon and she served the most aces (116) in a Slam in New York this year. In fact, she served an ace on championship point at both the Australian Open and US Open

Rybakina wins the way glaciers move: silently, relentlessly, until you look up one day and the entire landscape has changed. New York didn't just hand her a trophy; it handed women's tennis a warning wrapped in ice – quiet on the outside, catastrophic underneath



HEALTH

Why patient safety needs more than hospital checklists

Patient safety begins even before treatment: it encompasses the right diagnosis, accurate, timely care, safe hospital environments, protected data and an understanding from all stakeholders to put the patient first, say doctors; the WHO's theme for World Patient Safety Day 2026 is 'safe care for non-communicable diseases'

Siddharth Kumar Singh

A patient enters an operating theatre for a procedure on the right knee. The limb is marked, the scans are available and the surgical team has checked the records. Just before the operation begins, the team stops. A nurse reads out the patient's identity, the procedure planned, the side of the body to be operated on and the type of anaesthesia. The surgeon, anaesthetist and other members of the team confirm the details. This brief pause, known as 'timeout', may take only a few minutes. But it is one of several layers of checks designed to prevent a potentially devastating mistake.

This exercise was an example of what Syed Mohammed Ghouse, consultant robotic and transplant surgeon, Asian Institute of Nephrology and Urology, described as the 'Swiss cheese mechanism', in which several layers of checks are put in place so that if one safety barrier fails, another can detect the error before it reaches the patient.

The need for such multiple safeguards was at the heart of World Patient Safety Day, observed on September 17. The World Health Organization's theme for 2026 was 'Safe care for non-communicable diseases'.

Doctors say patient safety has to be viewed much more broadly than preventing an obvious surgical or medication error. Ranga Reddy Burri, president, Infection Control Academy of India, said the understanding of patient safety has now expanded considerably: the responsibility cannot rest only with doctors and nurses. Policymakers, accreditation agencies, patients, caregivers, families, communities and even housekeeping staff have roles to play. "A hospital just having an accreditation doesn't actually guarantee the kind of safety that is required," Dr. Burri said, stressing the need to train all stakeholders involved in a patient's journey.

Patient safety begins even before treatment starts, noted Dr. Burri. The availability of sophisticated diagnostic equipment has not necessarily solved the problem of ensuring an accurate diagnosis. "The diagnosis quality has actually gone down over a period of time," he said. He attributed part of the problem to doctors moving away from basic clinical examination, including auscultation, percussion, palpation and physical examination. He described the emerging situation as 'no touch' healthcare, where doctors can sometimes begin looking at a computer even before adequately engaging with the patient.

Neurologist Sudhir Kumar of Apollo



Safety first: Hospital staff conducted a mock drill on mass casualty management earlier this year at the Government General Hospital in Ongole. Experts say all stakeholders should have training in patient safety. KOMMURI SRINIVAS

Hospitals, Hyderabad, also pointed to the importance of ensuring quality of medical education as the number of medical colleges and seats increases. "If we don't ensure quality services, then it will worsen the patient's safety because diagnosis may be missed; treatment may not be perfect," he said.

Medication problems

Medication safety remains another major area of concern. Dr. Kumar said spurious and fake medicines continue to pose a patient-safety risk despite the existence of drug inspectors and regulatory checks.

Dr. Ghouse pointed to another problem of look-alike and sound-alike medicines. With a large number of pharmaceutical companies and medicines available, drugs with similar names can create opportunities for errors, particularly when medicines are handled by someone who is distracted or not sufficiently alert.

He said hospitals use measures such as separate labelling and storing look-alike and sound-alike medicines away from each other, along with other quality-control measures.

Technology has reduced some types of prescription errors, but doctors say it has not eliminated them. Dr. Ghouse said typed and printed prescriptions are still not universal, especially at small clinics. Dr. Kumar said prescription errors can also occur when different doctors prescribe medicines under different

brand names or when medicines from the same group are inadvertently duplicated. "For example, a patient may end up taking the same medicine twice because different brand names make it difficult to recognise that the drugs are essentially the same."

Within hospitals

Some patient-safety risks are less dramatic but can still have serious consequences, particularly among older patients. Dr. Burri said falls in hospitals, including falls while patients are going to the bathroom or getting out of bed, can result in major injuries. "Hospitals need to ensure that their physical environments are designed to prevent slipping and other hazards."

Patient safety also extends beyond just their wards or rooms. Dr. Kumar pointed to hospital fires, electrical problems and other infrastructure-related hazards as areas that require greater attention. He said while the number of hospitals was increasing, some facilities are decades old, raising questions about who regularly audits their wiring and electrical connections.

For Dr. Burri, infection prevention and antimicrobial resistance (AMR) remain central to the patient-safety conversation. Unnecessary antibiotic administration, delayed diagnosis, unhygienic environments and non-adherence to infection-prevention and control guidelines can all contribute to the

problem, he said.

These risks can become particularly important for patients with chronic diseases, who may require repeated interactions with healthcare facilities. Dr. Burri said patients with conditions such as chronic kidney disease, lung diseases and cancer may have vulnerabilities that make infection prevention an important component of safe care. "Healthcare workers and administrators therefore have a central role in ensuring that infection-control practices are followed," he added.

Data and AI

As healthcare becomes increasingly digital, patient safety is also becoming connected to data privacy. Dr. Kumar said medical information is private, but increasing digitisation has created new risks around cybersecurity and access to medical records.

Artificial intelligence is increasingly entering healthcare, but Dr. Kumar said it should remain a tool rather than become a substitute for clinical reasoning.

For all the technology, protocols and checklists being introduced in hospitals, the doctors point to one element that cannot be removed from the equation, the patient. Dr. Burri said patients, families, caregivers and communities must understand their own role in ensuring safety.

(siddharth.kumar@thehindu.co.in)

THE GIST

Doctors say patient safety has to be viewed much more broadly than preventing an obvious surgical or medication error. Policymakers, accreditation agencies, patients, caregivers, families, communities and even housekeeping staff have roles to play in patient safety

Doctors also attribute part of the problem to doctors moving away from basic clinical examination, including auscultation, percussion, palpation and physical examination. They describe the emerging situation as 'no touch' healthcare, where doctors can sometimes begin looking at a computer even before adequately engaging with the patient

For all the technology, protocols and checklists being introduced in hospitals, the doctors point to one element that cannot be removed from the equation, the patient. Dr. Burri said patients, families, caregivers and communities must understand their own role in ensuring safety

HUMERUS



Melanoma in India: messaging about skin cancer needs to change, to catch it early

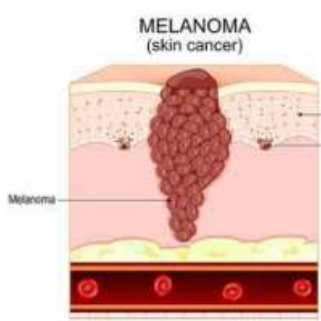
Jyoti Bajpai

Thousands of patients in India are diagnosed with melanoma, a type of skin cancer, each year.

While melanoma is far less common here than in Western populations, it is far from rare and the way it presents in our patient population makes it uniquely difficult to detect early. Too many patients come to us when the disease is already advanced, precisely at a time when treatment options have never been more powerful or more personalised. This contrast between available therapies and the stage at which patients are diagnosed defines one of the most pressing challenges in melanoma care in India today.

The warning signs most people associate with skin cancer come from research developed for fairer-skinned populations, where melanoma tends to appear on sun-exposed areas as an irregular or darkening mole. That picture does not reflect what clinicians see in India.

Melanoma here, most commonly presents on the soles of the feet or beneath the nails, sites that are rarely examined and even more rarely associated with cancer. This condition is called



Spreading awareness: Thousands of patients in India are diagnosed with melanoma, a type of skin cancer, each year. GETTY IMAGES

acral lentiginous melanoma, a subtype that accounts for 35 to 60% of cases in dark-skinned individuals. Such lesions are frequently mistaken for bruises, fungal infections, or diabetic ulcers, and by the time a biopsy is taken, the disease has often progressed.

Mucosal melanomas, a rare type of cancer that starts in the mucous membranes, are highly aggressive with a very low chance of recovery and produce few early warning signs. Most are diagnosed only after spread has occurred.

Any pigmented lesion that changes or persists, wherever it appears on the body, deserves investigation rather than reassurance.

When I began my oncology career, managing advanced melanoma meant offering patients limited and rarely durable options. That has fortunately changed significantly.

The foundational shift came from James Allison and Tasuku Honjo, whose discoveries on CTLA-4 and PD-1 earned them the 2018 Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine. Their research established the principle of immune-checkpoint blockade: rather than attacking a tumour directly, we can sometimes release the biological brakes that stop the patient's own immune system from doing so. The results can be extraordinary.

Precision medicine has reshaped the approach in parallel. Some melanomas carry specific mutations, particularly in the BRAF pathway, that can be directly targeted with molecularly designed therapies. This is where next-generation sequencing, or NGS, becomes critical. In simple terms, it reads the genetic blueprint of a patient's tumour and identifies the alterations that should guide treatment, turning what was once a single clinical decision into a detailed, individualised process.

The melanoma story is not over; it is only becoming more

exciting. TIL therapy takes tumour-infiltrating lymphocytes, expands them in the laboratory, and reinfuses them in far greater numbers, a step toward truly personalised cellular treatment. In August 2026, intismeran, a personalised mRNA vaccine built from the patient's own tumour sequence, was combined with pembrolizumab in high-risk melanoma patients after surgery. The results were striking: a significant reduction in recurrence compared with pembrolizumab alone, making it the first positive late-stage trial of a personalised mRNA cancer vaccine, though survival data remain pending.

What still needs to change

All of these advances deliver their best results when treatment begins early. The more sophisticated our therapies become, the more clearly we see that they work best before the disease has spread. In India, awareness and referral gaps continue to push diagnosis toward advanced stages.

(Prof. Jyoti Bajpai is director – medical precision immuno-oncology, Apollo Hospitals, Mumbai & Western Zone drjyoti_ba@apollohospitals.com)

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Increase in Indian utilities' August coal imports

5.52 million metric tonnes. Indian power producers' coal imports in August rose to a 15-month high as a heatwave and lower hydropower generation boosted electricity demand. Coal imports jumped 85.6% year-on-year to 5.52 million metric tonnes. REUTERS

Number of deceased persons returned to Ukraine by Russia

252 Ukraine has received the bodies of 252 people in an exchange of war dead with Russia, Ukrainian authorities said on Thursday. Russia received 23 bodies in return, Russian lawmaker Shamsail Saraliev was quoted as saying by the RBK news outlet. AFP

Private capital attracted by the World Bank

112 in \$ billion. The World Bank on Thursday said it attracted \$112 billion in private capital in the year ended June versus \$69 billion a year earlier, and more than triple the amount in fiscal 2022 before former Mastercard CEO Ajay Banga became president. REUTERS

Amount to be spent on defence by Ukraine in 2027

4.9 in trillion hryvnia. The Ukrainian government plans to spend two-thirds of its budget on defence next year. Russia's four-and-a-half-year offensive has battered Ukraine's economy, causing billions of dollars in destruction and punching a huge hole in its neighbour's finances. AFP

Number of taluks declared drought-hit in Karnataka

124 The Karnataka government on Thursday declared 23 more taluks drought-affected, taking the total number of drought-hit taluks notified so far to 124, amid dry conditions in several parts of the State. PTI
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What is the Uniform Civil Code debate?

How are personal laws governed today? What does the Constitution say about a UCC? What are the arguments in favour of a UCC? What are the arguments against? How could a UCC guarantee equal women's rights? What alternative has been proposed?

EXPLAINER

Rangarajan R.

The story so far:

Union Home Minister Amit Shah has indicated that the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) would be implemented in all 21 NDA-ruled States by 2029. Uttarakhand has had a UCC in force since January 2025, while UCC bills passed by the legislatures of Assam, Gujarat and Madhya Pradesh are awaiting Presidential assent.

How are personal matters governed today?

Article 44 of the Constitution provides that the State shall endeavour to secure a UCC for citizens throughout India. A UCC would apply the same set of secular personal laws to all people, irrespective of religion, caste, or tribe. India already has uniform criminal laws and common civil laws covering matters such as taxation, contracts, and negotiable instruments.

However, in matters such as marriage, divorce, and inheritance of property, various religious communities in India follow personal laws that are based on their religious doctrines. Hindus are governed by laws such as the Hindu Marriage Act (1955) and the Hindu Succession Act (1956), while many tribals within the Hindu religion may follow customary family laws under constitutional exceptions. Jains, Buddhists and Sikhs are covered by Hindu laws. Sikh marriages can also be registered under the Anand Marriage Act (2012). Christians and Parsis have their own personal laws, while Muslims are governed by the Muslim Personal Law (Shariat) Application Act (1937).

What are the pros and cons?

The Constitution makers were divided over including a UCC in the Constitution.



GETTY IMAGES

Some wanted it to be made a Fundamental Right to ensure uniformity in civil laws and secure equal rights for women. However, many members of the Muslim community were not in favour of including it in the Constitution as they felt that a uniform civil code would violate the fundamental right to religion that is guaranteed in Part III. Finally, the provision relating to UCC was placed in the non-justiciable Part IV - Directive Principles of State Policy.

There are several arguments over aspects of the UCC. The key arguments in its favour are, first, that it would make India secular in the true sense by subjecting all citizens to the same personal laws. The second and most vital argument is gender justice: a UCC would ensure equal rights for women across religions in matters governed by personal laws.

The key arguments against UCC are as follows. First, there can be potential conflict between the provisions of the UCC and guaranteed fundamental rights. Article 25 of the Constitution guarantees every person a fundamental right to practise a religion of one's choice. Article 29 provides a fundamental right to any section of citizens to conserve their distinct culture. The provisions of a UCC on personal matters may run contrary to scriptures and cultural doctrines in a religion. Second, the four States that have enacted UCC have exempted tribal population from its ambit. The reasons for such exemption are constitutional safeguards to protect tribal culture as well as the belief that many tribal customs in these matters provide adequate rights to women. However, exempting one section of society while making it compulsory for all other groups, including religious

minorities, is discriminatory.

What can be the way forward?

The most important reason to reform civil laws is to ensure equal rights for women in matters of marriage, divorce, maintenance, and inheritance. The right to religion under Article 25 is subject to constitutional morality and other fundamental rights, including equality. In Section 6A of the Citizenship Act, 1955 (2024) case, the Supreme Court held that practices such as casteism and gender discrimination, which run against the spirit of the Constitution, would not receive protection under Article 29. Thus, reforms in personal laws should not be viewed as violating Articles 25 and 29, as they uphold women's equality, an essential facet of constitutional morality.

However, there is resistance to the UCC among minorities, particularly Muslims. In the Constituent Assembly, Dr. B.R. Ambedkar advocated a UCC but suggested that it could remain voluntary. He said Parliament could provide for the UCC to apply to citizens who declare they are willing to be bound by it.

On the other hand, the Law Commission in its Consultation Paper on Reform of Family Law (2018) opined that a UCC was neither necessary nor desirable at this stage. It argued instead for reforming discriminatory provisions across personal laws. The emphasis should be on achieving 'equality within communities' between men and women rather than 'equality between communities.' The report recommends legislative reforms required in various personal laws with respect to marriage, divorce, custody, adoption, maintenance, succession and inheritance, that would ensure gender justice. The suggestions of the Law Commission should be considered while legislating and implementing reforms in personal laws. (Rangarajan R is a former IAS officer and author of 'Courseware on Polity Simplified'. Views expressed are personal)

THE GIST

▼ The Uniform Civil Code (UCC) would replace religion-based personal laws governing matters such as marriage, divorce and inheritance with a common set of secular laws

▼ Supporters argue that it would promote secularism, national integration and gender justice, while critics point to possible conflicts with religious and cultural rights

▼ The Law Commission has instead favoured reforming discriminatory provisions in existing personal laws to ensure equality between men and women

Why was ex-Kosovo President convicted by The Hague?

What was Thaci's role in the Kosovo Liberation Army? How has the verdict been received?

Joan Sony Cherian

The story so far:

Hashim Thaci, the former President of Kosovo, has been sentenced to 25 years in prison after being found guilty of war crimes by a special European Union-backed court at The Hague. The trial found him guilty of war crimes including murder, arbitrary detention, illegal arrests, torture, etc during the Kosovo war in the late 1990s as a senior commandant of the Kosovo Liberation Army (KLA). Three other former KLA commanders were also sentenced for several different charges.

What happened?

Thaci was a former commandant of the KLA, a militant ethnic Albanian force, formed in the early 1990s, which strove for the independence of Kosovo, composed primarily of ethnic Albanians, from Yugoslavia and Serbia.

Kosovo was once part of the erstwhile Republic of Yugoslavia. After the Second World War, the Kingdom of Yugoslavia

was reconstituted as the Socialist Federal Republic of Yugoslavia under the leadership of Josip Broz Tito. While Tito was able to unify the multiple republics, including Croatia, Montenegro, Serbia, Slovenia, Bosnia and Herzegovina, and Macedonia, and the autonomous provinces of Kosovo and Vojvodina, under a centralised government, the system came under pressure after his death. Multiple factors, including divisions between the republics, rising nationalist movements, economic pressures, and the disintegration of the Soviet Union, contributed to Yugoslavia's eventual dissolution in 2003.

One of the primary nationalist trends that spearheaded Yugoslavian dissolution was the Serbian nationalist movement led by Slobodan Milošević in the late 1980s. Riding on Serbian nationalist tendencies, Milošević pushed through policies that stripped other republics and provinces, such as Kosovo, of their autonomy. He also brought in policies that were discriminatory in nature against Albanians.

The KLA was formed in this

atmosphere to fight for the independence of ethnic Albanians in Kosovo, then a province within Serbia. The KLA led an insurgency against the Yugoslav state, attacking Serbian government buildings and police stations. This eventually led to an all-out war in 1998-1999, with the Serbian-controlled federal republic brutally cracking down on the KLA. The war led to the displacement of thousands of people and the death of nearly 13,000 people, mostly ethnic Albanians. The war finally ended with the intervention of NATO (the North Atlantic Treaty Organization), which carried out air raids and bombardments against Serbian targets, which forced the federal republic to end hostilities and move out of Kosovo. NATO subsequently deployed peacekeeping forces to the region.

Milošević eventually stood trial for his crimes against humanity, genocide, and war crimes committed during the Yugoslav Wars of the 1990s, in The Hague in 2002. However, he died in prison before a judgment was reached.

In 2008, Kosovo declared independence from Serbia and was

recognised by the U.S. and several other European nations. However, Serbia does not recognise Kosovo as an independent nation and still considers it a part of itself even though it has no administrative control over it. It is still not a member state of the UN. India also does not recognise Kosovo as an independent nation.

What was the trial for?

The trial was heard by the European Union-backed Kosovo Specialist Chambers, a special tribunal court constituted in The Hague in 2016, to hear the crimes committed by the KLA during the period of insurgency and subsequent war of the 1990s. The need for such a tribunal arose after Swiss politician Dick Marty authored a Council of Europe report, known as the Marty report, in 2010, which alleged that the KLA placed many Serbians in secret detention centres where they were subjected to inhuman and degrading treatment, before ultimately "disappearing". Of particular note was the allegation that the KLA had harvested the organs of such prisoners to sell them in the international market.

The report, in effect, coloured the larger imagination of the KLA and the Kosovo independence movement. The narrative changed from the KLA being seen as a champion of self-determination to an inhumane militia which had committed human rights abuses against Serbian nationals.

At least 15 people have been charged by the Chambers, with Thaci being the most senior figure. Charges were brought

against him in 2020, when he was President of Kosovo, following which he had to resign and stand trial as an ordinary citizen. The central question before the court was to understand the extent of the commandants' control over the KLA and whether the crimes amounted to a pattern of abuse. Finally, presiding judge Charles Smith stated that Thaci had "actively participated in and encouraged crimes," adding that "the scale and nature of the crimes committed were very serious". However, the judge insisted that the trial was "not about the legitimacy of the Kosovo Liberation Army" or its ultimate goal of securing independence for Kosovo.

What has been the reaction?

The verdict is a significant fall for Thaci, who was once regarded by Western powers as central to Kosovo's post-war future. In Kosovo, where Thaci is still seen as a revolutionary figure, the verdict was met with outrage and tears. Kosovo's Prime Minister Albin Kurti said the verdict was "a travesty of justice". People who had poured into the streets of Pristina, the capital of Kosovo, to hear the verdict were shocked and shouted slogans in support of the KLA and Thaci.

However, the Serbian side has welcomed the judgement. Serbia's Deputy Prime Minister Ivica Dacic called the verdicts a "warning" to Pristina "that a fake state cannot be built on mass graves of murdered Serbs".

Thaci and the three other commandants have the right to appeal the decision.

A man in a green shirt is working behind a counter in a small shop. The background shows shelves stocked with various goods. In the foreground, there are three digital payment QR code stands: PhonePe, paytm, and G2.

Who has to pay MDR on UPI and who stands to gain the most?

S CH-CHE